

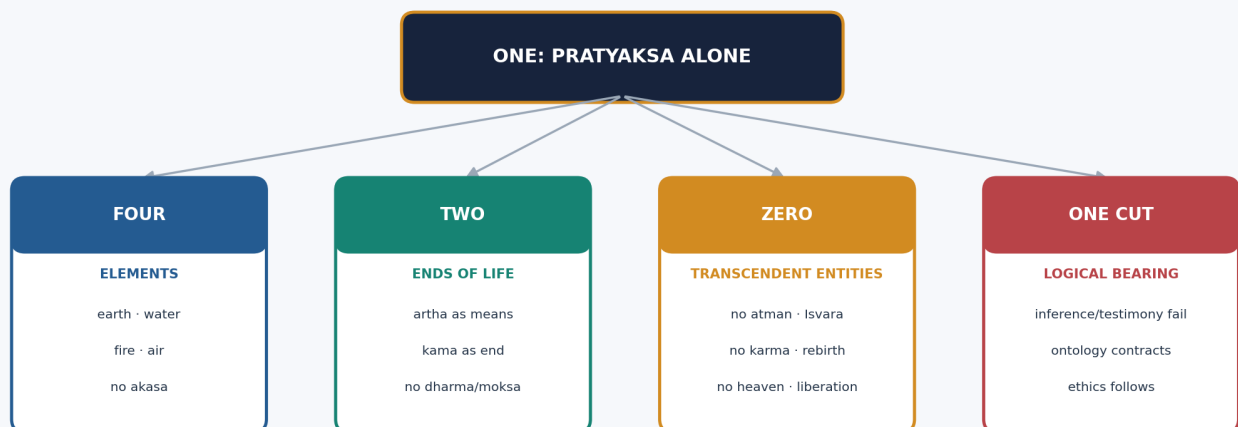
COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Cārvāka / Lokāyata - Theory of Knowledge and Rejection of Transcendent Entities - Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

CARVAKA: ONTOLOGY AS THE SHADOW OF EPISTEMOLOGY

Only perception is a truth-guaranteeing pramana



ONE pramana · FOUR elements · TWO purusharthas · ZERO transcendent entities

Exam logic: derive each denial from the epistemic restriction; do not present a disconnected list.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Cārvāka / Lokāyata - Theory of Knowledge and Rejection of Transcendent Entities - Complete Learning Session

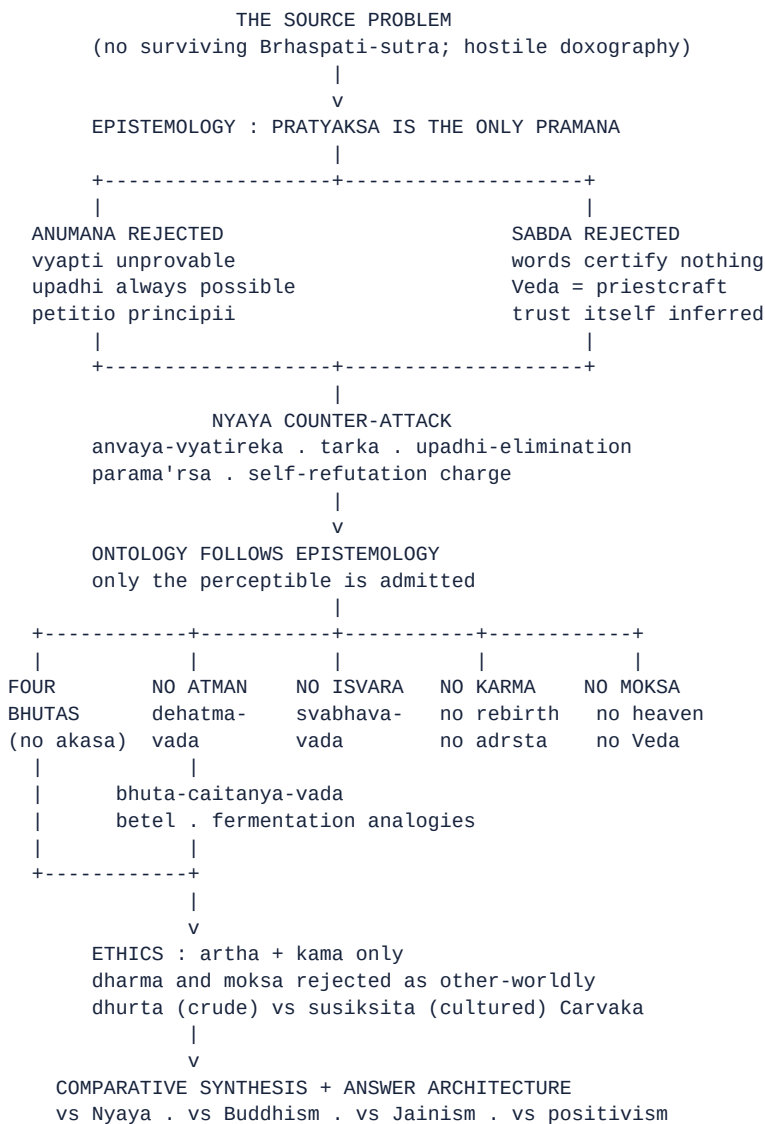
UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper I · Section B · Indian Philosophy · Syllabus item 12

Date of session: 10 August 2026 · Progress: 0/9 · Estimated effort: 6–8 sittings

Evidence key used throughout: FACT: canonical doctrine directly grounded in the authored knowledge file or in a local OCR-searchable source text · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis / inference for exam use · □ contested, textually uncertain or transmitted only through hostile doxography · □ clearly labelled contemporary *conceptual* parallel, never presented as a dated current-affairs item and never as authority.

Sources actually used for this session. FACT: Authored Markdown paper-1/indian/Carvaka.md (read in full); FACT: Satishchandra Chatterjee and Dhirendramohan Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*, Chapter II, "The Cārvāka Philosophy" — read from the two local OCR-searchable copies; FACT: C. D. Sharma, *Indian Philosophy: A Critical Survey*, Chapter Three, "Materialism"; FACT: paper-1/indian/Jainism.md for the 2020 Cārvāka–Jaina comparison; FACT: paper-1/_PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md for exact question wording. Qdrant was not required and did not block the session.

Roadmap



2. The source problem, stated precisely

FACT: The facts, as the standard textbooks state them.

1. No systematic primary work of the school survives. Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not find any systematic work on materialism, nor any organised school of followers as the other philosophical schools possess."
2. The *Brhaspati-sūtra* is lost. Sharma: about **a dozen** *sūtras* and verses are found quoted or referred to by other authors as the materialistic teachings of Brhaspati.
3. "Almost every work of the other schools states, for refutation, the materialistic views. Our knowledge of Indian materialism is chiefly based on these" (Chatterjee and Datta).
4. Sharma is blunter about the consequence: "the weak points in this school are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture."
5. Sharma adds the decisive historiographical warning: even the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary "seems to be based on such accounts", so it does not give independent access to the school.

ANALYSIS: **What follows philosophically.** Three consequences, each usable as a line in an answer:

- (a) MODAL CAUTION : write "on the standard reconstruction", not "Carvaka says in his text".
- (b) CHARITY : where a doctrine has a crude and a defensible version, the crude one is the one an enemy would preserve. Reconstruct the strongest available reading and SAY that you are doing so.
- (c) NON-PARALYSIS : convergence across independent hostile sources on the same doctrinal core (perceptualism, anti-inferentialism, four elements, no soul, no afterlife) is itself evidence.

3. The surviving fragments — what is actually quoted

FACT: Sharma gleans the following from the *Brhaspati* material quoted across philosophical writings. These are the closest thing to primary text that exists, and they are quoted *by others*:

#	Sūtra (as transmitted)	Doctrine
1	<i>prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni</i>	Earth, water, fire and air are the elements
2	<i>tatsamudāye śarīrendriyaviśaya-saṃjñā</i>	Bodies, senses and objects are results of different combinations of the elements
3	<i>kiṃvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam</i>	Consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents
4	<i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i>	The person is the body qualified by consciousness
5	<i>kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i>	Enjoyment is the only end of human life
6	<i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	Death alone is liberation

FACT: Alongside these, the second act of Kṛṣṇamiśra's allegorical play *Prabodhacandrodaya* summarises the doctrine in a single sweep: "Lokāyata is the only *śāstra*; perception is the only authority; earth, water, fire and air are the only elements; enjoyment is the only end of human existence; mind is only a product of matter. There is no other world; death means liberation."

□ **Caution to carry through the whole session.** A play written by an opponent, staged as allegory, is a *representation* of the doctrine. It is legitimate evidence of how the school was understood; it is not the school's own voice.

4. Why Cārvāka is nāstika — and the exact sense of the word

FACT: This is a precision point that separates strong scripts from weak ones. Chatterjee and Datta set it out exactly:

Sense of āstika	Meaning in Sanskrit philosophical literature	Is Cārvāka nāstika in this sense?
Primary, classificatory sense	One who accepts the authority of the Vedas	FACT: Yes — this is the sense that generates the six- <i>āstika</i> / three- <i>nāstika</i> division

Sense of āstika	Meaning in Sanskrit philosophical literature	Is Cārvāka nāstika in this sense?
Secondary sense	One who believes in life after death	FACT: Yes
Modern vernacular sense	"Theist" versus "atheist"	ANALYSIS: Misleading. Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā and early Yoga-adjacent readings are non-theistic yet āstika

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta state the consequence directly: the six orthodox schools are *āstika*, "and the Cārvāka is *nāstika* in both the senses". Jaina and Bauddha schools are *nāstika* on the first criterion but would count as *āstika* on the second, since they accept life after death.

MEMORY: **Trap, and it is examined:** *Cārvāka is nāstika primarily because it rejects Vedic authority, not merely because it denies God.* If denial of God were the criterion, Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā would also be *nāstika* — and they are not.

5. Why materialism arose — the historical setting

FACT: Sharma gives the standard account: the school "seems to be very old", with references in the epics and in early Buddhist literature; Garbe is quoted to the effect that "even in the pre-Buddhistic India proclaimers of purely materialistic doctrines appeared." Sharma locates its rise in the post-Upaniṣadic and pre-Buddhistic age and attributes it to:

1. protest against the excessive monkdom of the Brāhmaṇa priests;
2. the externals of ritualism, "which ignored the substance and emphasized the shadow";
3. an Upaniṣadic idealism "unsuited to the commoners";
4. political and social crises, exploitation of the masses by petty rulers, monks and the wealthy class.

FACT: Early Buddhist scripture confirms an environment of such thinkers. The *Sāmaññaphala-sutta* names four contemporaries of the Buddha whom Chatterjee and Datta group as "cunning (*dhūrta*) Cārvākas":

Thinker	Position as reported
Pūraṇa Kassapa	Denies moral responsibility, virtue and vice
Makkhali Gosāla	Denies free will and the possibility of moral effort
Ajita Kesakambalī	Teaches the material origin and destructibility of man, the futility of good action, the impossibility of knowledge
Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta	Will neither affirm, nor deny, nor both, nor even admit that he neither affirms nor denies

FACT: Sharma independently notes Ajita Kesakambalin in the *Majjhima Nikāya* as "a materialist ... who believed only in perception and in four elements", and records that Śāntarakṣita refers to him as *Kambalāśvatara*.

ANALYSIS: **Exam use.** Naming Ajita Kesakambalī gives you a *pre-systematic historical anchor* for four-element materialism that is independent of the hostile Brahmanical doxography — a genuinely strong evidential move in a 15- or 20-marker on sources.

6. Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa — the one surviving text, and why it must be handled carefully

FACT: **The facts.** Chatterjee and Datta: the *Tattvopaplavasiṃha*, by Jayarāśi, "probably of the eighth century A.D.", is a "recently discovered manuscript" and "an interesting specimen of Indian absolute scepticism"; its author "is believed to be a Cārvāka (or Lokāyatika) of an **extreme type**." Sharma records the publication data: it is the "single exception" to the absence of extant works, published by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940.

FACT: **What Jayarāśi actually does.** He "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of **perceptual** knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements. With a relentless destructive dialectic he exposes the defects of all the usually accepted sources of knowledge." His conclusion, Chatterjee and Datta note, is that of "an anti-intellectualist pragmatist": even on the denial of all theoretical principles and doctrines, practical life will go on as ever with unreflective ease.

ANALYSIS: The distinction that must be preserved.

STANDARD CARVAKA

Perception is VALID
Four elements are REAL
Positive materialist ontology
Rejects inference and testimony
= dogmatic empiricism

JAYARASI'S SCEPTICISM

Perception is ALSO attacked
Even the elements are not admitted
NO positive ontology at all
Rejects EVERY pramana
= universal scepticism (tattva-upaplava,
"the upsetting of all principles")

ANALYSIS: **Why this matters for the exam.** It is tempting, and wrong, to use Jayarāśi as evidence for what "the Cārvākas" held about perception. If Jayarāśi is used to establish the school's epistemology, the school's *defining* thesis — that perception alone is a *pramāṇa* — disappears. Use him for exactly two things: (i) as the sole surviving text-witness of the tradition, and (ii) as the internal limit-case showing where consistent Cārvāka scepticism, pressed hard, ends up.

7. Solved PYQ material — the source problem inside an answer

ANALYSIS: No PYQ asks directly about sources; every PYQ is improved by one sentence about them. Use one of these calibrated formulations:

Marks	Sentence to insert	Where
10	"Since the <i>Bṛhaspati-sūtra</i> is lost, the position is reconstructed from doxographies such as the <i>Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha</i> ."	After the opening definition
15	"Because the sources are refutational, the crude version of any Cārvāka doctrine is the one most likely to have been preserved; the argument below therefore reconstructs the strongest defensible reading."	Before the critical evaluation
20	"The historiographical caution cuts both ways: it forbids confident quotation, but the convergence of Buddhist (<i>Tattvasaṅgraha</i>), Advaita (<i>Vedāntasāra</i>), Jaina (<i>Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya</i>) and Advaita-adjacent doxographical accounts on the same doctrinal core is itself independent evidence for that core."	In the evaluation paragraph

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Cārvāka was not marginal to Indian philosophy; it was structural.** Chatterjee and Datta make the point in their concluding section and it is worth reproducing as an evaluative sentence: "every system of Indian thought tried to meet the Cārvāka objections and made the Cārvāka a **touchstone** of its theories." They add that its value "lies directly in supplying fresh philosophical problems and indirectly in compelling other thinkers to give up dogmatism, and become critical and cautious in speculation as well as in the statement of views" — and they compare this to Kant's admission that "the scepticism of Hume roused me from my dogmatic slumber."

ANALYSIS: **Sharma's counterweight, which a balanced answer should also carry:** "Materialism in Indian Philosophy has never been a force. Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought." The two verdicts are not contradictory: Cārvāka failed as a *positive system* while succeeding as a *critical function*. That two-sided judgement is exactly the graded verdict UPSC rewards.

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ The reconstruction problem here belongs to a general class: how to state fairly a position preserved only in the words of those who rejected it. The same methodological question arises in reading the Greek Sophists through Plato, or the Presocratics through Aristotle. ANALYSIS: Use this as a *methodological* remark of one sentence. It is a conceptual parallel, **not** a dated development, and it must never be written as though it were news.

UPSC traps

- Do not write that "Cārvāka wrote the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*". The text is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive only as quotations in other authors' works.
- ANALYSIS: Do not treat the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* as an independent primary source. Sharma explicitly says its summary "seems to be based on" the same refutational accounts.

3. ANALYSIS: Do not use Jayarāṣi's *Tattvopaplavasīṃha* to state the Cārvāka theory of knowledge. He attacks perception too, which no standard Cārvāka does.
4. FACT: Do not say Cārvāka is *nāstika* "because it is atheist". It is *nāstika* because it rejects the authority of the Veda — and, in the second textbook sense, because it denies life after death.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present the "asura-deception" story about Bṛhaspati as history.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not conclude from the source problem that "nothing can be known". Convergent hostile testimony still fixes a doctrinal core.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse *Lokāyata* ("view of the common people") with "folk religion". It names a philosophical position, not a devotional practice.

Revision notes

- FACT: Three names: **Cārvāka** (*carv*, to chew / *cāru-vāk*, sweet-worded), **Lokāyata** (*lokāyata-mata*, the view of common people), **Bārhaspatya** (of Bṛhaspati).
- FACT: Bṛhaspati is the traditional founder; his *Sūtra* is lost; about a dozen *sūtras* survive as quotations.
- FACT: Knowledge of the school comes chiefly from works that state its views **in order to refute them**.
- FACT: Sharma's verdict on transmission: strong points omitted, weak points exaggerated — "a faint caricature and not a true picture".
- FACT: Six transmitted *sūtras* to memorise: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness like intoxicating power · person = body qualified by consciousness · *kāma* the only end · death alone is liberation.
- FACT: *Prabodhacandrodaya* Act II gives the classic one-sentence summary of the school.
- FACT: **Nāstika in both senses**: rejects Vedic authority; denies life after death. Vedic authority is the primary classificatory criterion.
- FACT: *Sāmaññaphala-sutta* names Pūraṇa Kassapa, Makkhali Gosāla, Ajita Kesakambalī and Sañjaya Belaṭṭhiputta as the environment of early scepticism and materialism.
- FACT: Ajita Kesakambalī — "believed only in perception and in four elements" — is the best independent historical anchor for the doctrine.
- FACT: **Jayarāṣi Bhaṭṭa**, *Tattvopaplavasīṃha*, c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — the single surviving text, but an extreme sceptic who attacks perception itself.
- ANALYSIS: Cārvāka was the **touchstone** every school had to answer; its historical value is critical rather than constructive.
- ANALYSIS: Two-sided verdict to carry: philosophically fertile as critique (Chatterjee–Datta), unsuccessful as a system (Sharma).

MCQ 1

Which of the following most accurately states the *primary* classificatory reason Cārvāka is grouped among the *nāstika* schools of Indian philosophy?

- A. It rejects the authority of the Vedas, which is the standard Sanskrit philosophical criterion of *āstika*; on the secondary criterion it is also *nāstika* because it denies life after death.
- B. It denies the existence of God, which is what *nāstika* means in Sanskrit philosophical literature.
- C. It denies the existence of the external world and therefore falls outside the orthodox fold.
- D. It was founded later than the six orthodox systems and so could not be admitted into the *āstika* list.

FACT: **Correct answer: A.** Chatterjee and Datta state the two senses explicitly: *āstika* means one who believes in the authority of the Vedas, or one who believes in life after death, and "the Cārvāka is *nāstika* in both the senses." B is the modern vernacular sense, and it fails immediately, because Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā are non-theistic yet *āstika*. C inverts the doctrine — Cārvāka is a realist about the perceptible world. D confuses chronology with classification.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 2

A candidate writes: "The *Tattvopaplavasīṃha* of Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa is the surviving primary text of the Cārvāka school, and it therefore gives us direct access to the Cārvāka theory that perception alone is a valid means of knowledge." What is the decisive error?

- A. Jayarāṣi was a Naiyāyika, not a Cārvāka.
- B. Jayarāṣi's work is sceptical about perception itself and refuses to admit even the physical elements, so it cannot be used to establish the standard Cārvāka thesis that perception alone is a *pramāṇa*.
- C. The *Tattvopaplavasimha* is not extant; only fragments are quoted by other authors.
- D. Jayarāṣi accepts inference and therefore contradicts nothing in Cārvāka epistemology.

FACT: **Correct answer: B.** Chatterjee and Datta describe Jayarāśi as a Cārvāka "of an extreme type" who "carries the scepticism of the ordinary Cārvāka to its logical conclusion by challenging the validity of perceptual knowledge and refusing to accept the existence of even the physical elements." A is false — he is placed inside the tradition. C is false — Sharma records its publication by the Oriental Institute of Baroda in 1940, and it is precisely the "single exception" to the loss of the corpus. D reverses his position; he rejects *all* the accepted sources of knowledge.

FACT: Subtopic 1 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now state the nomenclature, the source situation and the exact sense in which Cārvāka is *nāstika*, and you can distinguish the historical school from Jayarāśi's radical scepticism. Proceeding to the theory of knowledge.

Progress: 2 / 9 | Stage: Foundation | Subtopic: Epistemology — Perception as the Sole *Pramāṇa*

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

- Book context: Carvaka.md §1.1, §1.4 and §1.7 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §II ("The Cārvāka Epistemology"), including sub-sections 1 ("Inference is not Certain") and 2 ("Testimony is not a Safe Source of Knowledge"), read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III ("Epistemology") read directly.
- CA Search: "empiricism, perception and the limits of testimony — Cārvāka epistemology, developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** There is no credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ A clearly labelled *conceptual* link to contemporary debates about the epistemology of testimony and misinformation is given at the end of the subtopic; it is a conceptual parallel, not a current-affairs anchor, and carries no evidential weight in the answer.

[illegible]

□□ VISUAL — The pramāṇa ledger of Indian philosophy, and where Cārvāka stands

	pratyakṣa (percep.)	anumāna (infer.)	upamāna (compar.)	śabda (test.)	arthapatti (postul.)	anupalabdhi (non-cogn.)	
CARVAKA	YES	no	no	no	no	no	= 1
Vaisesika	YES	YES	no	no	no	no	= 2
Buddhism	YES	YES	no	no	no	no	= 2
Samkhya / Yoga	YES	YES	no	YES	no	no	= 3
Nyaya	YES	YES	YES	YES	no	no	= 4
Prabhakara Mimamsa	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	no	= 5
Bhatta Mimamsa / Advaita Vedānta	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	= 6

$\wedge$
 $|$
 CARVAKA SITS AT THE MINIMUM OF THE LEDGER.
 Everything else in the system follows from that single cell.

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** This ledger is worth reproducing from memory in any *pramāṇa* question in Paper I. It shows at a glance that the Cārvāka position is not an eccentric outlier but the **lower bound** of a shared Indian debate about how

many independent sources of knowledge there are. Nyāya sits at four; Cārvāka drives the number down to one and forces every other school to justify its additions.

1. The core thesis, stated exactly

FACT: **Thesis (pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda)**. Perception alone is a *pramāṇa* — an independent, dependable source of valid knowledge (*pramā*).

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta frame the architecture of the whole system on this thesis: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend **logically** on their epistemology." Every later denial — of soul, God, *karma*, rebirth, heaven and liberation — is a consequence drawn from this one epistemic restriction, not a separate act of unbelief.

FACT: The vocabulary must be precise:

Term	Meaning	Why the exam cares
Pramā	Valid cognition; knowledge of reality	The thing to be explained
Pramāṇa	The <i>means</i> by which <i>pramā</i> arises	The disputed list
Pratyakṣa	Perception	The only item Cārvāka admits
Anumāna	Inference	Rejected as uncertain
Śabda	Verbal testimony, including scripture	Rejected as derivative
Upamāna	Comparison / analogy	Rejected with the rest

ANALYSIS: **The condition Cārvāka imposes**. Chatterjee and Datta state it as a conditional test: "If inference is to be regarded as a *pramāṇa*, it must yield knowledge **about which we can have no doubt** and **which must be true to reality**." Note the strength of the demand. This is not "usually reliable"; it is indubitability plus correspondence. Every subsequent Cārvāka argument is an application of this standard.

2. Two kinds of perception, and why the Cārvāka needs both

FACT: Cārvāka accepts perception in both its classical forms, and the second is often forgotten by candidates:

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PRATYAKSA
|
+--- BAHYA (external) : through the five external senses --
|   sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell                       |
|                                                                 | > both admitted
+--- ANTARA / MANASA (internal) : the mind's immediate        |
|   awareness of pleasure, pain, desire, and                  |
|   consciousness itself                                     -----

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FACT: This is not a decorative detail. Chatterjee and Datta present the strongest objection to Cārvāka materialism precisely through internal perception: "do we not have a kind of perception, called internal, which gives an immediate knowledge of our mental states? And do we not perceive in these consciousness which is nowhere to be perceived in the external material objects?" The objector's aim is to force the admission of an immaterial substrate.

FACT: **The Cārvāka answer, and it is subtle**. "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." Consciousness is *given*; a soul is *not* given. What internal perception delivers is a state of the living body, not evidence of a separate substance.

ANALYSIS: **Exam-critical inference**. Cārvāka is therefore **not** a denier of consciousness. It is a denier of the *inference* from consciousness to an immaterial bearer of consciousness. A script that writes "Cārvāka denies consciousness" has confused materialism with eliminativism and has thrown away the 2024 twenty-marker.

3. Certainty versus practical belief — the distinction that saves the position

ANALYSIS: The most common failure in this topic is to write that "Cārvāka says nobody ever infers anything." That is not the doctrine, and the texts themselves block it.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's own concession: "It is true that in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference. But that only shows that we act **uncritically** on the wrong belief that our inference is true. It is a fact that sometimes our inference comes true and leads to successful results. But it is also a fact that sometimes

inference leads to error as well. **Truth is not then an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a separable one**, that we find only in some inferences."

ANALYSIS: Unpack that last sentence, because it is the philosophical hinge of the whole topic.

For inference to be a PRAMANA, truth would have to be an
ESSENTIAL and INSEPARABLE character of the inferential process.

But truth attaches to SOME inferences and not to others.

=> truth is ACCIDENTAL (agantuka) to inference, and SEPARABLE from it.

=> inference is not a truth-GUARANTEERING instrument.

...and yet people go on inferring, and often succeed.
The Carvaka does not deny THAT. He denies that success confers
PRAMANA-STATUS.

FACT: The authored knowledge file records the same distinction under the heading *lokasiddha* or *laukika* inference: practical, corrigible, worldly inference tied to future perceptual confirmation is tolerated; **transcendental** inference — from ritual to unseen merit, from world to God, from body to soul — is the real target, because nothing could ever check it perceptually.

Axis	Everyday (laukika / vyāvahārika) inference	Transcendental (alaukika / pāramārthika) inference
Example	Smoke on a hill, so probably fire; dark clouds, so probably rain	Ritual now, so heaven later; world exists, so God made it
Corrigibility	FACT: Can be checked by later perception	ANALYSIS: In principle uncheckable
Cārvāka attitude	ANALYSIS: Tolerated as practical habit; denied <i>pramāṇa</i> -status	FACT: Rejected outright
What the exam wants	The distinction stated in one sentence	The target of the critique identified correctly

4. Why śabda falls — the argument in five steps

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta give a compact and precise argument, worth reproducing as numbered steps:

1. Testimony consists of **words** (*śabda*). Insofar as words are heard through our ears, they are **perceived** — and knowledge of words is therefore perceptual and quite valid.
2. But insofar as those words *suggest or mean* things not within our perception, and aim at giving knowledge of unperceived objects, "they are not free from error and doubt."
3. Reliance on an authority always proceeds through a suppressed inference. The believer's mind runs: "This authority should be accepted because it is reliable, and all reliable authority should be accepted."
4. That is an inference. "Being based on inference, knowledge derived from verbal testimony or authority is **as precarious as inference**."
5. Therefore testimony is not an *independent* source of knowledge.

FACT: The special case of the Veda. Chatterjee and Datta report the Cārvāka verdict without softening: "The authority of the Vedas ... is held in high esteem by many. But in reality the Vedas are the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous. With false hopes and promises the Vedas persuade men to perform Vedic rites, the only tangible benefit of which goes to the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

ANALYSIS: Two distinctions to keep clean.

- (1) WORDS AS SOUNDS : perceived, and therefore fine.
WORDS AS EVIDENCE : not perceived, and therefore suspect.
- (2) REJECTING TESTIMONY $\neq$ REJECTING COMMUNICATION.
Language can guide action; it cannot CERTIFY what it reports
until perception catches up with it.

FACT: Sharma adds the reinforcing point that testimony cannot be used to rescue inference either: "if testimony proves *vyāpti*, inference would become dependent on testimony, and then **none would be able to infer anything by**

himself." That reductio is worth a line in any answer on the rejection of inference.

5. Why upamāna, arthāpatti and anupalabdhi fall too

ANALYSIS: Cārvāka's argument is a single template applied repeatedly, and stating the template is more impressive than listing the *pramāṇas*.

Pramāṇa	Its claim	The Cārvāka template applied
Upamāna (Nyāya)	From "the <i>gavaya</i> resembles the cow" plus later sight of the animal, one knows the word's referent	ANALYSIS: The similarity is perceived; the <i>linkage of name to kind</i> is a generalisation reaching beyond what is perceived, hence inferential and insecure
Arthāpatti (Mīmāṃsā)	Devadatta is fat, yet does not eat by day; therefore he eats by night	ANALYSIS: A postulation to remove an inconsistency — but the postulated fact is unperceived, and the necessity of the postulation is itself a generalisation
Anupalabdhi (Bhāṭṭa, Advaita)	Non-apprehension of the jar yields knowledge of its absence	ANALYSIS: Requires the rule "if it existed here it would have been perceived", which is a universal not given in any single perception

ANALYSIS: **The template in one line, for the answer script:** *every candidate pramāṇa other than perception depends on a universal proposition, and no universal proposition is perceived.* That single sentence disposes of the whole list and shows the examiner you understand the structure rather than the catalogue.

6. What the position buys, and what it costs

	Strength FACT:	Cost ANALYSIS:
Epistemic	An austere, honest criterion; no unfalsifiable postulates	Knowledge shrinks to the present-and-perceived; science and history become impossible as <i>knowledge</i>
Ontological	No inflated metaphysics; explanatory economy	Cannot account for micro-entities, other minds or the past
Religious	Immunity to priestly manipulation and unverifiable promises	Loses any account of moral order beyond prudence
Dialectical	Forces every rival to justify each additional <i>pramāṇa</i>	Invites the self-refutation charge (Subtopic 3)

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Cārvāka's scepticism is selective, and Sharma turns that selectivity into an objection.** Śūnyavāda Buddhism and Advaita Vedānta also reject the *ultimate* validity of inference — but, as Sharma notes, "the Śūnyavādin and the Advaitin reject the ultimate validity of **all** means of knowledge as such **including perception**, though they insist on the empirical validity of all means of knowledge. The distinction between ultimate and empirical knowledge is **unknown to the Cārvāka**. To accept the validity of perception and, at the same time and from the same standpoint, to reject the validity of inference is a thoughtless self-contradiction."

ANALYSIS: This gives you a **three-way comparison** that very few candidates will produce:

School	Perception	Inference	Level-distinction available?
Cārvāk a	FACT: Valid, full stop	WRONG: Rejected, full stop	WRONG: None — hence Sharma's charge of "same standpoint" inconsistency
Śūnya vāda	ANALYSIS: Empirically valid, ultimately not	ANALYSIS: Empirically valid, ultimately not	FACT: <i>Samvṛti</i> / <i>paramārtha</i>
Advait a	ANALYSIS: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> validity only	ANALYSIS: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> validity only	FACT: <i>Vyāvahārika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i>

ANALYSIS: **The Cārvāka's best available repair**, and you should offer it before evaluating: *adopt the level-distinction*. If the Cārvāka says "inference has *vyāvahārika* usefulness but no *pāramārthika* validity", Sharma's charge of same-standpoint inconsistency loses its grip — at the price of conceding that the doctrine is a thesis about

certainty rather than about usability. That is precisely the softened reading defended in Subtopic 3.

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ The Cārvāka analysis of *śabda* — that a hearer's acceptance of testimony always runs through a suppressed premise about the speaker's reliability — is the ancestor of the modern **reductionist** position in the epistemology of testimony, and it is the exact point at issue in contemporary debates about credibility and misinformation. ANALYSIS: Label it as a conceptual parallel in a single clause if at all; do not import modern examples into a Paper I answer in place of *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *śabda*, and do not present it as a dated event.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write "Cārvāka accepts only perception **and** ordinary experience" as if these were two things. Ordinary experience is admitted as perception.
2. FACT: Do not forget internal perception. Its admission is what makes Cārvāka a materialist about consciousness rather than a denier of consciousness.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Cārvāka rejects language or communication. It rejects testimony's claim to *independent pramāṇa-status*.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not list the rejected *pramāṇas* without giving the single template that rejects them all: each rests on an unperceived universal.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the *vyāvahārika* / *pāramārthika* level-distinction to Cārvāka as a historical doctrine. Sharma's point is precisely that Cārvāka lacks it; offering it is a philosophical *repair*, and it must be labelled as such.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not confuse the Cārvāka's demand ("no doubt whatever, and true to reality") with modern fallibilist standards. The strength of the demand is what drives the entire critique.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not say the Vedas are rejected "because they are old" or "because they are religious". They are rejected because their authority cannot be perceptually certified and their content promises the unperceivable.

Revision notes

- FACT: *Pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*: perception alone is a *pramāṇa*; everything else in the system follows logically from this.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend logically on their epistemology."
- FACT: The Cārvāka's test for *pramāṇa*-hood: knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".
- FACT: Both **external** and **internal** perception are admitted; consciousness is perceived, an immaterial soul is not.
- FACT: Cārvāka denies the *inference* from consciousness to a soul, not consciousness itself.
- FACT: "Truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an accident, and a **separable** one."
- ANALYSIS: Distinguish *laukika* (corrigible, practical) from *pāramārthika* (uncheckable, transcendental) inference; the second is the real target.
- FACT: *Śabda* in five steps: words heard are perceived -> what they *mean* is unperceived -> acceptance runs through a reliability inference -> inference is precarious -> testimony is not independent.
- FACT: Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved *vyāpti*, "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- FACT: The Veda is rejected as the work of "cunning priests" whose promises benefit only the officiants — an epistemic charge with a sociological edge.
- ANALYSIS: The single template that kills *upamāna*, *arthāpatti* and *anupalabdhi*: each needs an unperceived universal.
- ANALYSIS: Sharma's charge: Cārvāka accepts perception and rejects inference **from the same standpoint**, lacking the *saṃvṛti/paramārtha* or *vyāvahārika/pāramārthika* distinction that saves Śūnyavāda and Advaita.

MCQ 3

The Cārvāka admits internal perception (*mānasa-pratyakṣa*) and grants that consciousness is established by it. Which conclusion does the Cārvāka draw, and which does he refuse to draw?

- A. He draws the conclusion that consciousness is unreal, and refuses the conclusion that the body exists.
- B. He draws the conclusion that inference is valid within the mental domain, and refuses to extend it to external objects.
- C. He draws the conclusion that consciousness exists as a perceived fact of the living body, and refuses the further inference that consciousness must be the quality of an unperceived non-material substance.
- D. He draws the conclusion that the soul is perceived directly, and refuses only the claim that it is eternal.

FACT: **Correct answer: C.** Chatterjee and Datta put it exactly: "The Cārvākas admit that the existence of consciousness is proved by perception. But they deny that consciousness is the quality of any unperceived non-material or spiritual entity." A makes Cārvāka an eliminativist, which he is not; B invents a domain-restricted acceptance of inference found nowhere in the sources; D contradicts the school's core denial of *ātman*.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 4

Consider the Cārvāka's argument against *śabda* as an independent *pramāṇa*. Which statement best captures its logical structure?

- A. Words are unreal, therefore what they express is unreal.
- B. Scripture is composed by human beings, therefore all its statements are false.
- C. Testimony is valid only when the speaker is a *ṛṣi*, and no *ṛṣi* can be perceived today.
- D. Hearing a word is perceptual and therefore valid, but moving from the word to the unperceived object it reports requires the suppressed premise that reliable authority should be accepted — which is an inference, and inference is itself unproved.

FACT: **Correct answer: D.** This reproduces the argument in Chatterjee and Datta: knowledge of words is perceptual and "quite valid", but insofar as words "suggest or mean things not within our perception ... they are not free from error and doubt", and the belief in the authority is "generated by a mental process" that is plainly inferential — hence testimony is "as precarious as inference". A misstates the position, since words are perceived and real. B is a non sequitur that no Cārvāka source asserts in that form. C invents a condition of reliability that the Cārvāka never accepts.

FACT: Subtopic 2 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now state the sole-*pramāṇa* thesis, defend the admission of internal perception, separate certainty from practical belief, and dispatch *śabda* and the remaining *pramāṇas* with one template. Proceeding to the critique of inference itself.

Progress: 3 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Critique of Inference — *Vyāpti*, *Upādhi*, the Socrates Syllogism and Self-Refutation

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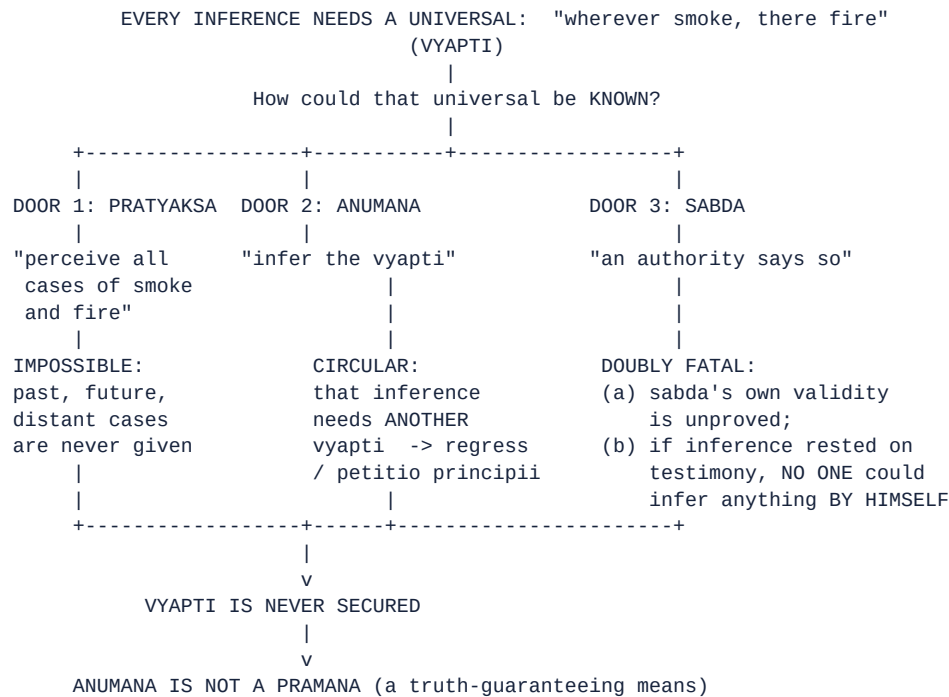
PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

Book context: Carvaka.md §1.2, §1.3, §1.6 and §1.7 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §II.1 ("Inference is not Certain") — including the *sāmānya* / class-character objection and the *upādhi* of wet fuel — read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III, on deduction as *petitio principii* and induction as an unwarranted leap, read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for the exact 2019 Q6(c) and 2025 Q5(a) wording.

CA Search: "problem of induction, inference under uncertainty, Cārvāka anumāna — developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months**. No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. The perennial problem of induction and modern reasoning under uncertainty are flagged at the end as clearly labelled *conceptual* parallels only.

□□ VISUAL — The three-door trap: how vyāpti is cornered



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** Draw this in the answer booklet. Three doors, all shut — that is the entire 2025 ten-marker, and the spine of the 2018, 2019 and 2022 questions. Notice that Door 3 is shut *twice*, and the second bolt (Sharma's "none would be able to infer anything by himself") is the one most candidates miss.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

FACT: **Thesis.** *Anumāna* is not a *pramāṇa*, because inference is "a mere leap in the dark" (Sharma): we proceed from the known to the unknown, and there is no certainty in this, "though some inferences may turn out to be **accidentally** true."

FACT: **The structural point.** Inference is a movement from a perceived mark (*liṅga*, e.g. smoke) to an unperceived *sādhya* (e.g. fire), licensed by an invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*) between them. Chatterjee and Datta present the Naiyāyika's own fuller statement of the inference — "all cases of smoke are cases of fire; this mountain is a case of smoke; therefore this is a case of fire" — and then locate the Cārvāka attack precisely: the argument "would be acceptable only if the **major premise**, stating the invariable relation between the middle term and the major, were beyond doubt."

ANALYSIS: **The move to memorise.** The Cārvāka never attacks the *form* of the inference. He grants that if the major premise were secure the conclusion would follow. He attacks the **licence** — the universal proposition that makes the movement legitimate. This is why the correct one-line statement of the doctrine is: *the Cārvāka critique of inference is a critique of the grounding of vyāpti, not of syllogistic validity.*

2. Door 1 — vyāpti cannot be established by perception

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "this invariable relation (*vyāpti*) can be established only if we have a knowledge of **all** cases of smoke and presence of fire. This, however, is not possible, as we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing **now** in different parts of the world, to speak nothing of those which existed in the **past** or will exist in the **future**."

OBSERVED SET		UNIVERSAL CLAIMED
-----		-----
[kitchen fire]		ALL smoke, everywhere,
[hill fire]	---- ? ---->	at every time, past,
[hearth fire]		present and future
[...n cases]		
finite, present,		infinite, temporally
local, contingent		unbounded, exceptionless
+--> the gap here is not a gap of DEGREE. It is a gap of KIND.		

FACT: **The class-character (sāmānya) rejoinder, and the Cārvāka's answer.** This is the sharpest exchange in the topic and almost no candidate reproduces it. The Naiyāyika-style objector says: granted we cannot perceive all individual smokes, but can we not perceive the **class-characters** "smokeness" (*dhūmatva*) and "fireness" (*vahnitva*), and perceive a relation *between the universals*, and thereby license the inference?

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta record the Cārvāka's two-part reply verbatim in substance:

1. Even granting perception of a relation between smokeness and fireness, "we cannot know therefrom any invariable relation between **all individual cases** of smoke and fire. To be able to infer a **particular** fire, we must know that it is inseparably related to the **particular** smoke perceived."
2. Worse, "it is not possible even to **know by perception** what 'smokeness' ... is, because we do not perceive all cases of smoke."

ANALYSIS: **What this exchange really shows.** The Cārvāka refuses to let the Naiyāyika escape the particular–universal gap by relocating it in the universals: the same finitude that blocks the enumeration of instances blocks the perceptual grasp of the class-character. Chatterjee and Datta conclude for him: "the difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal, therefore, remains here as before."

3. Door 2 — vyāpti cannot be established by inference

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Neither can it be said to be based on another inference, because it will involve a **petitio principii**, since the validity of that inference again has to be similarly proved."

FACT: Sharma sharpens the same point into a pair:

DEDUCTION : "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; so Socrates is mortal."
The conclusion is ALREADY CONTAINED in the major premise.
=> petitio principii, an argument in a circle.

INDUCTION : offered to establish the major premise.
But induction "proceeds unwarrantedly from the known to the unknown."
=> the major premise is never secured.

RESULT : "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle.
The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference." (Sharma, quoting the Carvaka gibe)

ANALYSIS: **Why this is not merely a dilemma but a trap.** Each horn is repaired only by the other. Deduction's circularity is cured by grounding the major premise inductively; induction's insecurity is cured by grounding it deductively. The Cārvāka's point is that the two cures are the same wound seen from two directions.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta add the causal variant, which candidates often think is a way out: "can we not base our knowledge of the invariable relation between smoke and fire on a **causal** relation between them?" The Cārvāka reply: "a causal relation, being only a kind of invariable relation, cannot be established by perception owing to the same difficulties."

4. Door 3 — vyāpti cannot be established by testimony

FACT: Two independent bolts, and both should appear in a 15-marker:

1. FACT: "Nor can this *vyāpti* be based on the testimony (*śabda*) of reliable persons ... For, the validity of testimony **itself requires to be proved by inference**" (Chatterjee and Datta). Grounding inference in testimony and testimony in inference is a closed circle.
2. FACT: "Besides, if inference always depended on testimony, **no one could infer anything by himself**" (Chatterjee and Datta; Sharma states the same *reductio*). Inference is manifestly a first-person cognitive capacity; making it parasitic on the word of another misdescribes what inference is.

5. The upādhi problem — the deepest cut

FACT: **Statement.** Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition (*upādhi*) may be doing the work; so observed constancy never establishes *unconditional* concomitance.

FACT: **The textbook example, exactly as Chatterjee and Datta give it** — and note that it runs in the direction most candidates get backwards:

A man perceives fire accompanied by smoke, many times.

On another occasion he perceives FIRE and infers SMOKE.

AAAA AAAAA

He is liable to ERROR.

Why? Because he failed to notice a CONDITION (upadhi):
WETNESS OF FUEL -- on the presence of which ALONE fire is
attended with smoke.

The relation "fire -> smoke" holds only ARDRENDHANA-SAMYOGA-SAHITE,
i.e. where fire is joined with wet fuel. A red-hot iron ball is
fire WITHOUT smoke.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta draw the general conclusion: "So long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be **unconditional**, it is an uncertain ground for inference. And unconditionality or **absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice**. Inference or testimony cannot be used for proving this unconditionality without a *petitio principii*, because its validity also is being questioned here."

ANALYSIS: **Why the upādhi argument is stronger than the enumeration argument.** The enumeration argument says: you have not checked enough cases. The *upādhi* argument says: **even if you had checked every case you can check, you could not know that you had identified the right property as the ground of the relation**. The first is a problem of quantity; the second is a problem of the *identification of the relevant variable*. Nyāya can answer the first with more observation. It cannot answer the second with more observation alone — which is why it must bring in *tarka* (Subtopic 4).

6. Solved PYQ — 2019, Q6(c), 15 marks: the Socrates syllogism

FACT: **Exact question.** "What is wrong according to the Cārvākas with the following argument? All men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, Socrates is mortal. Justify your answer with arguments."

ANALYSIS: **What the question is really testing.** Whether the candidate can apply the *vyāpti* critique to a *deductive* syllogism rather than reciting the smoke-and-fire example. The examiner has deliberately chosen a Western textbook syllogism whose validity is not in dispute, in order to see whether the candidate attacks the right thing.

ANALYSIS: **Model answer (≈245 words).**

The Cārvāka objection is **not** that the argument is formally invalid. If the premises hold, the conclusion follows. The objection is directed at the **major premise**, "All men are mortal", which functions here exactly as *vyāpti* does in Indian inference — an invariable, exceptionless concomitance between man-ness and mortality.

How is that universal known? Not by **perception**: no one has perceived all men — past, present, future, near and distant. Chatterjee and Datta press exactly this point: we cannot perceive even all present cases, "to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future." Not by **inference**: any inference to the universal would itself require a further universal, generating a *petitio principii* or a regress. Not by **testimony**: testimony's own validity is established only inferentially, and if inference depended on testimony "no one could infer anything by himself."

Hence the syllogism is, in Sharma's formulation, an **argument in a circle**: "Socrates is mortal" is already contained in "All men are mortal." The deduction merely extracts what induction failed to establish. And *upādhi* deepens the objection: perhaps what is genuinely invariable is not man-ness with mortality but embodiment-with-organic-decay under conditions never fully surveyed.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The Cārvāka charge is that the syllogism is **valid but epistemically empty**: it transmits a certainty in the major premise that was never independently acquired. That is a serious charge about induction, though the Cārvāka must still answer how his own universal denial of inference is known.

ANALYSIS: **The four things this answer must contain, and no answer without them scores well:** (i) explicit refusal to attack validity; (ii) the major premise identified as *vyāpti*; (iii) the three-door argument applied; (iv) the *petitio principii* formulation of deduction plus one line of self-critical balance.

7. The self-refutation charge (2018, 2019, 2022) — and the Cārvāka's replies

FACT: The charge, in its strongest form. Sharma states it without mercy: "To refuse the validity of inference from the empirical standpoint is to refuse to think and discuss. All thoughts, all discussions, all doctrines, all affirmations and denials, all proofs and disproofs are made possible by inference. The Cārvāka view that perception is valid and inference is invalid **is itself a result of inference**. The Cārvāka can understand others only through inference and make others understand him only through inference. Thoughts and ideas, not being material objects, cannot be perceived; they can only be inferred. Hence the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy."

ANALYSIS: Reconstructed as numbered steps, because the examiner wants the logic and not the invective:

1. The Carvaka asserts: "No inference is a valid source of knowledge."
2. That assertion is UNIVERSAL. It quantifies over all inferential acts, past, present and future.
3. No universal proposition is given in any single perception.
4. Therefore the thesis is either (a) itself inferential -- and so self-defeating -- or (b) not knowledge by its own standard.
5. Further: to REFUTE Nyaya, the Carvaka must reason. To be UNDERSTOOD, he must rely on his hearers inferring his meaning from his words.
6. Further still: other MINDS are never perceived. The Carvaka's very act of arguing with an opponent presupposes an inference to another mind.

ANALYSIS: The Cārvāka's three available replies — a strong answer gives all three and grades them.

Reply	Formulation	Assessment
R1 — The "no thesis" or vitanḍā reply	The Cārvāka advances no positive doctrine; he only <i>destroys</i> the opponent's claim to certainty, using the opponent's own standards. A purely destructive dialectic incurs no commitments.	ANALYSIS: Coherent, but it converts Cārvāka from a philosophy into a method — and Cārvāka <i>does</i> assert four elements, a body-self and <i>kāma</i> as the end, so it cannot be a global reply.
R2 — The softened-thesis reply	The thesis is not "no one ever infers" but "inference never yields apodictic certainty beyond what perception can check". As a claim about certainty rather than usability, it is not refuted by the fact that the Cārvāka reasons.	ANALYSIS: The strongest reply. It is the reading the authored knowledge file endorses, and it rescues consistency at the price of weakening the doctrine into radical fallibilism.
R3 — The level-distinction reply	Concede <i>vyāvahārika</i> validity to inference and deny only <i>pāramārthika</i> validity.	ANALYSIS: Effective against Sharma's "same standpoint" charge, but the level-distinction is, as Sharma says, "unknown to the Cārvāka" — so it is a repair offered by the interpreter, and must be labelled as such.

ANALYSIS: The verdict to write. *Against the uncompromising formulation the self-refutation charge is decisive; against the softened formulation it loses its force but so does the doctrine, which becomes a fallibilist warning rather than a denial of a pramāṇa. The Cārvāka can be consistent or radical, but not both.* That sentence answers 2019 Q5(c) almost by itself.

8. Sharma's counter-attack on perception — the tu quoque

FACT: Sharma turns the Cārvāka's weapon around: "Perception itself which is regarded as valid by the Cārvāka is **often found untrue**. We perceive the earth as flat but it is almost round. We perceive the earth as static but it is moving round the sun. We perceive the disc of the sun as of a small size, but it is much bigger than the size of the earth. Such perceptual knowledge is **contradicted by inference**."

FACT: And the constructive half, which is really a Kantian point made in an Indian idiom: "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception or thought has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data." Sharma cites the Buddhist *Tattvasaṅgraha* for this line of attack.

ANALYSIS: Why this is devastating and must be handled, not avoided. If perception is fallible *and* is corrected by inference, then the very hierarchy Cārvāka asserts is inverted: inference becomes the tribunal before which perception is judged. A 15- or 20-mark answer that reproduces the Cārvāka case without meeting this rejoinder is one-sided.

ANALYSIS: **Best Cārvāka response available:** the errors Sharma lists are corrected by **further perception plus practical checking**, not by pure inference — and a fallibilist Cārvāka can concede correction within perception while still denying that any *unperceivable* entity is established by it. That reply is decent for the flat-earth case and weak for the heliocentric case, and you should say so.

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Distinguish two Cārvāka claims that are constantly run together in scripts:**

CLAIM A (epistemic) : inference does not GUARANTEE truth
-> defensible; almost universally granted today
CLAIM B (semantic/ : the words "wherever smoke, there fire" express
ontological) no knowable proposition at all
-> far stronger; hard to hold while doing philosophy

ANALYSIS: Most of the force of the Cārvāka critique lives in Claim A. Most of the vulnerability to self-refutation lives in Claim B. A first-class answer separates them and says which one it is defending.

ANALYSIS: **A further refinement on the target.** The Cārvāka's practical inferences are always **perceptually redeemable**: I infer fire, I climb the hill, I see fire. Transcendental inferences are **structurally unredeemable**: I infer heaven from *agnihotra*, and no perception could ever cash the claim. The Cārvāka's position becomes far more defensible when stated as: *an inference is worth something to the extent that its conclusion is in principle perceptually checkable* — which is a verificationist criterion in Indian dress, and is exactly the material needed for the 2024 "positivism" question.

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ The *vyāpti* argument is a strikingly early and complete statement of what Western philosophy calls **the problem of induction**: that no finite set of observations entails an unrestricted universal, and that attempts to justify induction inductively are circular. The *upādhi* argument anticipates the modern problem of **confounding variables** — the possibility that an observed regularity tracks an unnoticed third factor. ANALYSIS: These are conceptual parallels for one clause of comparative colour, not dated developments, and they must never displace the Indian vocabulary in a Paper I script.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not write that the Cārvāka says the syllogism is **invalid**. He says the major premise is ungrounded, and that deduction is therefore circular.
2. FACT: Do not give the *upādhi* example backwards. The standard case is inferring **smoke from fire**, which fails because the *upādhi* of **wet fuel** was unnoticed.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not omit the *sāmānya* / class-character exchange. It is the difference between a textbook answer and a top answer.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not present the self-refutation charge without the Cārvāka's replies. A one-sided demolition scores poorly on "critically examine".
5. ANALYSIS: Do not claim all inference is literally impossible for the Cārvāka. Distinguish *pramāṇa*-status from everyday expectation and practical action.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not forget Door 3's second bolt: if inference rested on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not ignore Sharma's *tu quoque* about perceptual error. Meeting it is what "critically evaluate" means.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not treat the causal-relation escape as untouched. A causal relation is itself a species of invariable relation and inherits the same problem.

Revision notes

- FACT: Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- FACT: The attack is on the **major premise** (*vyāpti*), never on syllogistic form.
- FACT: **Door 1 (perception)**: all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- FACT: **Class-character reply**: even *dhūmatva* and *vahnitva* cannot be perceptually known, since all instances are not perceived; and universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference.

- FACT: **Door 2 (inference):** *petitio principii* or infinite regress; deduction is circular, induction unwarranted.
- FACT: Causal relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- FACT: **Door 3 (testimony):** testimony's validity is itself inferred; and "if inference always depended on testimony, no one could infer anything by himself."
- FACT: **Upādhi:** the wet-fuel condition; unconditionality can never be perceptually certified because conditions may remain hidden.
- FACT: *Upādhi* is a problem of the *right variable*, not merely of *sample size* — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it.
- FACT: **Self-refutation:** the universal denial of inference is itself a universal; and other minds, thoughts and ideas are never perceived.
- ANALYSIS: **Three replies:** no-thesis (*vitaṇḍā*) · softened certainty-thesis · level-distinction. The second is strongest; the third is a repair, not a historical doctrine.
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's tu quoque:** flat earth, static earth, small sun — perception errs and is corrected *by inference*.
- ANALYSIS: **Verdict formula:** the Cārvāka may be consistent or radical, but not both.

MCQ 5

According to the standard Cārvāka critique, what exactly is defective in the argument "All men are mortal; Socrates is a man; therefore Socrates is mortal"?

- A. Nothing in its form, but the major premise states an unrestricted universal that cannot be established by perception, cannot be established by a further inference without circularity, and cannot be established by testimony — so the deduction merely re-states an unwarranted assumption.
- B. The middle term is undistributed, which makes the syllogism formally invalid.
- C. The conclusion asserts a future event, and no proposition about the future can be meaningful.
- D. Socrates is not perceived by the speaker, so no proposition about him can be entertained at all.

FACT: **Correct answer: A.** The Cārvāka grants formal validity and attacks the grounding of the universal, exactly as with *vyāpti*; Sharma adds that the conclusion is "already contained in the major premise", making the deduction a *petitio principii*. B misdescribes a valid Barbara syllogism. C imports a verificationist thesis about future-tensed statements that the Cārvāka never advances in this form. D would abolish testimony-based reference altogether, which even the Cārvāka does not do — he allows words as perceived sounds.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 6

Which of the following best explains why the *upādhi* objection is philosophically deeper than the objection from incomplete enumeration?

- A. Because *upādhi* shows that the observed cases were fabricated.
- B. Because incomplete enumeration is a defect of sample size, curable in principle by further observation, whereas *upādhi* shows that even exhaustively observed regularity may track an unnoticed condition — so the *identification of the relevant ground* of the relation, not merely the number of cases, is what remains uncertified.
- C. Because *upādhi* proves that causal relations do not exist.
- D. Because *upādhi* applies only to inference from effect to cause, which is the only kind of inference the Cārvāka rejects.

FACT: **Correct answer: B.** Chatterjee and Datta make the crucial point that "unconditionality or absence of conditions cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden and escape notice" — a defect that further counting cannot cure, and the reason Nyāya must introduce *tarka* rather than merely more observation. A misdescribes the argument, which concedes the observations. C overstates: the objection is epistemic, not a denial of causation as such. D invents a restriction found in no source; the Cārvāka's target is inference in general, and most sharply transcendental inference.

FACT: Subtopic 3 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now run the three-door argument, deploy *upādhi* correctly, answer the Socrates question, and both press and rebut the self-refutation charge. Proceeding to the Nyāya defence, without which no "critically examine" answer is complete.

Progress: 4 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: The Nyāya Defence of Inference — and a Critically Balanced Verdict

[illegible]

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

□ Book context: Carvaka.md §1.5 and §3.1 read in full; paper-1/indian/Nyaya-Vaisesika.md §§ on *vyāpti*, *bhūyodarśana*, *tarka*, *upādhi*-elimination and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, plus §11.2 on the Naiyāyika response to Cārvāka, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §III, on the Nyāya-side counter-attack including the *Tattvasaṅgraha* point about sensation requiring conception, read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for 2018 Q8(b) and the cross-linked 2022 Q7(c).

□ CA Search: "Nyāya theory of inference, vyāpti and tarka — scholarly developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka- or *anumāna*-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ A labelled conceptual parallel to modern accounts of inference under uncertainty is noted at the end and carries no evidential weight.

[illegible]

□□ VISUAL — How Nyāya actually builds a vyāpti, step by step

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STAGE 1 BHUYODARSANA (repeated observation)
+-----+
| ANVAYA      : wherever smoke, there fire| positive co-presence
| VYATIREKA   : where no fire, no smoke  | negative co-absence
+-----+
      |
STAGE 2 UPADHI-SANKA-NIRASA (elimination of suspected conditions)
"is there a hidden qualifier making the relation conditional?"
test each candidate: wet fuel? time? place? -> discard those
that do not survive joint presence/absence testing
      |
STAGE 3 TARKA (hypothetical/reductio reasoning)
"SUPPOSE smoke occurred without fire.
Then an effect would occur without its cause.
Then ANY effect could occur from ANY cause.
Then all practical life and all cognition collapse.
The supposition is therefore untenable."
-> tarka does not PROVE vyapti; it REMOVES the doubt that blocks it
      |
STAGE 4 SAMANYALAKSANA-PRATYAKSA (extraordinary perception of the universal)
through the perceived particular smoke, smokeness itself is
presented -- giving cognitive access to the CLASS, not merely
to the counted instances
      |
STAGE 5 VYAPTIGRAHA (the universal is grasped) --> stored as knowledge
      |
STAGE 6 LINGA-DARSANA : "there is smoke on that hill" (perception)
STAGE 7 PARAMARSA : "this hill has smoke WHICH IS INVARIABLY
ACCOMPANIED BY FIRE" <-- the operative cognition
STAGE 8 ANUMITI : "this hill has fire" (inferential knowledge)

```

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** The Cārvāka argues as if *vyāpti* had to be acquired in one impossible act of total enumeration. Nyāya's reply is architectural: *vyāpti* is **assembled** through five distinguishable operations, and the burden of certainty is distributed across them. Reproducing this eight-stage ladder is the single most effective way to show an examiner that you understand what Cārvāka is actually up against.

1. Why Nyāya cannot simply concede

ANALYSIS: Nyāya is the school of *pramāṇa*-theory. If inference falls, then *upamāna* falls with it, *śabda* loses its warrant, the proofs of God (*kāryāt*, *āyojanāt*, *dhṛtyādeḥ*, *padāt/śruteḥ*) collapse, the atomic theory becomes unstateable, and the Nyāya proofs of the self go with them. The Cārvāka attack is therefore not a peripheral irritant but an existential threat, which is why the Naiyāyika reply is so highly developed.

2. Anvaya and vyatireka — the joint method

FACT: **The doctrine.** *Vyāpti* is established by **bhūyodarśana**, repeated observation, but of a particular disciplined kind:

Method	Sanskrit	Form	Function
Method of agreement	anvaya	Wherever <i>hetu</i> , there <i>sādhya</i>	Establishes positive co-presence across varied cases
Method of difference	vyatireka	Wherever <i>sādhya</i> is absent, <i>hetu</i> is absent	Rules out cases where the mark occurs without the probandum
Joint method	anvaya-vyatireka	Both together	The absence of a single counter-instance across wide, varied observation

ANALYSIS: **The philosophical point to make explicit.** The Cārvāka treats repeated observation as mere counting. Nyāya treats it as **structured testing**: it is not the number of positive cases that matters but the survival of the relation through deliberate search for **negative** cases. A relation that survives systematic attempts to find *hetu*-without-*sādhya* has a warrant that a mere tally does not.

3. Upādhi-elimination — meeting the Cārvāka's strongest weapon

FACT: **The Nyāya procedure.** An *upādhi* is defined technically as a condition that pervades the *sādhya* but does not pervade the *hetu*. To test a suspected relation, the Naiyāyika asks whether any such condition can be found; where one is found, the *vyāpti* is reformulated to include it.

```
BAD VYAPTI : "wherever fire, there smoke"
UPADHI FOUND: wet fuel (ardra-indhana)
REPAIR      : "wherever fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke"
RESULT      : the conditional relation is not abandoned -- it is
               RESTATED at the correct level of generality.
```

ANALYSIS: **The concession Nyāya must make, and an honest answer states it.** Nyāya can eliminate *suspected* and *known upādhis*. It cannot demonstrate that **no upādhi** whatever remains undetected. What it claims instead is that a relation which survives systematic testing, negative-case search and *tarka* is **rationally warranted**, not that it is guaranteed by an omniscient survey.

ANALYSIS: **The move that decides the debate.** Nyāya shifts the standard from **impossible omniscience** to **disciplined rational warrant**. The Cārvāka has set a bar — indubitability plus correspondence — that nothing except present perception could clear, and even present perception clears it only if perceptual error is ignored. Nyāya's reply is that this bar is not a criterion of knowledge but a recipe for its abolition.

4. Tarka — the argument the Cārvāka has no answer to

FACT: **What tarka is.** *Tarka* is hypothetical reasoning, *reductio ad absurdum*: it assumes the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibits the unacceptable consequence. It is expressly **not** an independent *pramāṇa* in Nyāya; it is a *pramāṇa-anugrahaka* — an auxiliary that removes doubt so that *vyāptigraha* can occur.

```
SUPPOSE : smoke without fire
THEN     : an effect exists without its cause
THEN     : the causal order is arbitrary
THEN     : no expectation, no action, no discourse, no refutation
BUT      : the Carvaka HIMSELF acts, expects, argues and refutes
THEREFORE: the supposition is untenable (anista-prasanga)
```

ANALYSIS: **Why this is so powerful against Cārvāka specifically.** The Cārvāka concedes that people act on inference and that action often succeeds. *Tarka* converts that concession into a premise: the intelligibility of the Cārvāka's own practice — including the practice of arguing against Nyāya — presupposes the very regularities he refuses to certify. The Cārvāka can escape only by retreating to the softened thesis (Subtopic 3, reply R2), at which point the dispute becomes verbal rather than doctrinal.

5. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection

FACT: **The doctrine.** Nyāya admits an extraordinary (*alaukika*) perception in which, through a perceived particular, the **universal** itself is presented — smokeness through this smoke. The authored Nyāya file records the trap explicitly: it is an error to say that universals are not perceived in Nyāya; they are, through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.

ANALYSIS: **The exchange, laid out for the answer script:**

Move	Claim
Cārvāka	FACT: You cannot perceive all smokes; therefore you cannot perceive smokeness; therefore you have no universal
Nyāya	FACT: The universal is not reached by adding up particulars; it is presented in any particular through extraordinary perception
Cārvāka rejoinder	ANALYSIS: <i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i> is a technical device invented precisely to plug the hole; it is theory-laden, not independently attested
Assessment	ANALYSIS: Honest verdict: the device does real work inside Nyāya's realism about universals, but it will not convince anyone who does not already accept that realism. The debate here bottoms out in ontology, not in epistemology

6. Parāmarśa — what actually generates the inferential cognition

FACT: **The doctrine.** In Nyāya, inferential knowledge (*anumiti*) is produced by a specific operative cognition (*karaṇa*) called **parāmarśa**: the cognition of the mark *as qualified by* its invariable concomitance — "this hill possesses smoke, which is invariably accompanied by fire."

ANALYSIS: **Why this matters against Cārvāka.** The Cārvāka pictures inference as a **leap** across a gap: from perceived smoke, jump to unperceived fire. Nyāya's analysis denies that there is any leap at all. What produces the conclusion is a single complex cognition in which the mark is *already* apprehended under the concomitance. There is no moment at which the mind is stranded between premises with a chasm to cross.

ANALYSIS: **A memorable line for the answer:** *For Cārvāka, inference is a jump in the dark; for Nyāya, it is a step taken in the light of a concomitance already grasped.*

7. The Nyāya counter-attack on perception

FACT: Sharma reports this as the decisive counter-move, and it was set out in Subtopic 3 §8: perception itself errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — "such perceptual knowledge is contradicted by **inference**." And, following the *Tattvasaṅgraha*, "pure perception in the sense of mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless **conception or thought** has arranged into order and has given meaning and significance to the loose threads of sense-data."

ANALYSIS: **The structural result, and it is a genuine reversal:**

CARVAKA'S PICTURE	NYAYA'S CORRECTED PICTURE
-----	-----
perception = certain	perception = fallible, and CORRECTED by inference
inference = derivative	inference = the tribunal that corrects perception
hierarchy: P > I	hierarchy: neither is self-sufficient;
	perception supplies content,
	inference supplies order and correction

ANALYSIS: **Note the Nyāya distinction that keeps this honest:** Nyāya distinguishes **nirvikalpaka** (indeterminate, pre-predicative) from **savikalpaka** (determinate, qualified) perception. Only determinate perception is judgemental — and determinate perception already involves conceptual qualification. The Cārvāka's "pure given" is therefore, on the Nyāya analysis, either pre-cognitive and useless, or already conceptually shaped and therefore not the innocent bedrock he supposes.

8. Solved PYQ material — 2018, Q8(b), 15 marks, and its exact demand

FACT: **Exact question.** *"Is Cārvāka rejection of inference acceptable to the other systems of Indian philosophy? If not, why? Do you think the views of other systems to be justified? Give reasons for your answer."*

ANALYSIS: **The demand has three distinct limbs** and candidates routinely answer only the first:

LIMB 1 : IS IT ACCEPTED?	-> a survey across schools (mostly NO)
LIMB 2 : IF NOT, WHY NOT?	-> the reasons, school by school
LIMB 3 : ARE THEY JUSTIFIED?	-> the candidate's own graded verdict

ANALYSIS: **The cross-school survey table, which is the backbone of Limb 1 and 2:**

School	Accepts anumāna?	Its reason for refusing the Cārvāka
Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	FACT: Yes, as an independent <i>pramāṇa</i>	<i>Anvaya-vyatireka</i> + <i>upādhi</i> -elimination + <i>tarka</i> + <i>sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i> ; and the denial is itself inferential
Sāṃkhya–Yoga	FACT: Yes	<i>Prakṛti</i> , <i>puruṣa</i> and the <i>guṇas</i> are established by inference from perceptible effects; without inference the system cannot begin
Mīmāṃsā	FACT: Yes	Ritual injunction and <i>apūrva</i> require inference; and the Cārvāka's attack on <i>śabda</i> strikes at Mīmāṃsā's foundation
Jainism	FACT: Yes	<i>Matī</i> and <i>śruta</i> knowledge involve inference; and <i>anekāntavāda</i> requires the very universals Cārvāka denies
Buddhism	FACT: Yes (<i>pratyakṣa</i> and <i>anumāna</i>)	Dignāga and Dharmakīrti build an entire logic; and <i>Tattvasaṅgraha</i> attacks Cārvāka's naïve perceptualism directly
Advaita Vedānta	ANALYSIS: Yes at the <i>vyāvahārika</i> level	Rejects <i>ultimate</i> validity of all <i>pramāṇas</i> including perception — a level-distinction Cārvāka lacks

ANALYSIS: **Limb 3 — the graded verdict to write.** *The other systems are justified in rejecting the strong Cārvāka thesis, because a wholesale denial of inference is self-defeating and would abolish the very discourse in which it is stated. They are not entitled to treat the objection as disposed of, because Nyāya's positive account replaces the demand for certainty with a demand for warrant — a substitution that answers the Cārvāka only if fallibilism is accepted, which is itself a concession to him. The correct verdict is therefore that Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle: inference survives as a **pramāṇa**, but it survives as a warranted rather than an indubitable one.*

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **What the debate is really about, stated at the highest level.** Both sides agree that finite observation cannot logically entail an unrestricted universal. They disagree about what follows.

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CARVAKA : entailment fails => no knowledge => no pramana-status
NYAYA   : entailment fails => but WARRANT does not require entailment
                                => disciplined procedure yields knowledge
                                => pramana-status is preserved

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ANALYSIS: The disagreement is therefore about the **concept of knowledge**, not about the logic of induction, on which the two are in near-agreement. Writing that sentence identifies the true locus of the dispute and is the mark of a top script.

ANALYSIS: **The honest residue against Nyāya**, which a balanced answer must supply so as not to look partisan: (i) *tarka* is admittedly not a *pramāṇa* and cannot by itself establish anything; (ii) *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* is defensible only inside Nyāya's realism about universals, so it is not a neutral answer; (iii) the elimination of *upādhis* is always elimination of **suspected** conditions, never a proof that none remains. Nyāya's inference is therefore highly disciplined but not indefeasible — which is precisely what a fallibilist Cārvāka wanted to hear.

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ Nyāya's replacement of certainty by disciplined warrant, with negative-case testing and the systematic elimination of confounders, is conceptually parallel to modern accounts of **inference under uncertainty** — controlled comparison, elimination of alternative explanations, and degrees of confirmation rather than proof. ANALYSIS: Use at most one clause of this in an answer, explicitly as a conceptual analogy, never as a dated development or as authority.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not say Nyāya "proves" *vyāpti* with certainty. It claims disciplined warrant and eliminates *suspected* conditions.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not call *tarka* a *pramāṇa*. It is *pramāṇa-anugrahaka*, an auxiliary that removes doubt.
3. FACT: Do not write that Nyāya denies the perception of universals. It affirms it through *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*.

4. ANALYSIS: Do not omit *parāmarśa*. Without it, you cannot explain why Nyāya denies that inference is a "leap" at all.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not answer 2018 Q8(b) with only one school. The question says "the other systems" — plural — and asks for your own verdict as a third limb.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not present Advaita as agreeing with Cārvāka about inference. Advaita's denial is at the *pāramārthika* level and applies to perception equally.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not forget Nyāya's *nirvikalpaka* / *savikalpaka* distinction when replying to the "pure given" assumption.

Revision notes

- FACT: *Vyāpti* is built by **bhūyodarśana**, disciplined as **anvaya** (co-presence) and **vyatireka** (co-absence).
- FACT: **Upādhi**-elimination repairs a defective universal by restating it at the correct level of generality — "fire **with wet fuel**, there smoke".
- FACT: **Tarka** is hypothetical *reductio* reasoning; it is not a *pramāṇa* but removes the doubt blocking *vyāptigraha*.
- FACT: *Tarka*'s force against Cārvāka: his own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify.
- FACT: **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular.
- FACT: **Parāmarśa** — the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance — is the *karāṇa* of *anumiti*; hence no "leap".
- FACT: The eight-stage ladder: *bhūyodarśana* -> *upādhi*-elimination -> *tarka* -> *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* -> *vyāptigraha* -> *liṅga-darśana* -> *parāmarśa* -> *anumiti*.
- FACT: Sharma's counter-attack: perception errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) and is corrected **by inference**.
- FACT: *Tattvasaṅgraha* point: mere sensation is not knowledge until conception orders "the loose threads of sense-data".
- ANALYSIS: Nyāya's decisive move: replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined warrant** as the standard for *pramāṇa*-hood.
- ANALYSIS: Honest residue: *tarka* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; undetected *upādhis* cannot be excluded in principle.
- ANALYSIS: 2018 Q8(b) has **three** limbs — is it accepted, why not, and are the objectors justified. Answer all three.
- ANALYSIS: Verdict formula: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as warranted, not as indubitable.

MCQ 7

In Nyāya epistemology, what precisely is the role of *tarka* in establishing *vyāpti*?

- A. *Tarka* is a fifth independent *pramāṇa*, alongside perception, inference, comparison and testimony.
- B. *Tarka* directly perceives the universal through the particular, and thereby supplies the invariable concomitance.
- C. *Tarka* is not itself a *pramāṇa* but an auxiliary (*pramāṇa-anugrahaka*): by assuming the contradictory of the proposed relation and exhibiting an unacceptable consequence, it removes the doubt that would otherwise block the grasp of *vyāpti*.
- D. *Tarka* is the fallacy of the undistributed middle, which Nyāya uses to expose defective inferences.

FACT: **Correct answer: C.** *Tarka* is hypothetical *reductio* reasoning that clears doubt so that *vyāptigraha* can occur; Nyāya explicitly refuses it independent *pramāṇa* status. A promotes it wrongly to a *pramāṇa*; B describes *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, a different device; D confuses a supportive method with a formal fallacy.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 8

A candidate writes: "Nyāya answers the Cārvāka by proving *vyāpti* with complete certainty through repeated observation." Which correction is philosophically required?

A. Nyāya abandons *vyāpti* altogether and grounds inference in scripture.

B. Repeated observation is irrelevant in Nyāya, which grounds *vyāpti* solely in *tarka*.

C. Nyāya concedes that inference yields only probability, and therefore agrees with the Cārvāka that it is not a *pramāṇa*.

D. Nyāya does not claim an omniscient survey of all cases; it builds *vyāpti* through the joint method of co-presence and co-absence, elimination of *suspected upādhis*, *tarka* and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, thereby replacing the demand for indubitable certainty with a demand for disciplined rational warrant.

FACT: **Correct answer: D.** The authored Nyāya file states the position exactly: "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice." A is false — Nyāya makes inference independent of *śabda*. B discards *bhūyodarsana*, which is the first stage of the ladder. C misstates the outcome: Nyāya insists on *pramāṇa*-status precisely while conceding that certainty is not achieved by enumeration.

FACT: Subtopic 4 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now defend inference on Nyāya's behalf, meet the Cārvāka's strongest weapon, and deliver a balanced verdict rather than a partisan one. Proceeding to metaphysics, where the epistemology begins to pay out.

Progress: 5 / 9 | Stage: Core | Subtopic: Metaphysics and Materialism — Four *Bhūtas*, the Rejection of *Ākāśa*, and *Svabhāva*vāda

[illegible]

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

□ Book context: Carvaka .md §2.1, §2.2, §2.4, §2.6 and the restored 2018/2020 doctrine dossier on *ākāśa* read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III ("Metaphysics"), sub-sections 1 ("The World is made of Four Elements") and 3 ("There is no God"), read directly from the local OCR-searchable copy; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §IV ("Metaphysics"), including the transmitted *Bṛhaspati sūtras* and Sadānanda's fourfold classification in the *Vedāntasāra*, read directly.

□ CA Search: "physicalism, emergent consciousness and material monism — Cārvāka four elements, developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ Contemporary physicalism and the debate over emergence are used at the end of this subtopic strictly as labelled *conceptual* links, not as current affairs.

□ □ **VISUAL** — The elemental ledger, and the one cell that is empty

	PRTHIVI (earth)	AP (water)	TEJAS (fire)	VAYU (air)	AKASA (ether/space)	
NYAYA-VAISESIKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	(+ kala, dik, atman, manas = 9 dravyas)
SAMKHYA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	(from tanmatras)
JAINISM	(pudgala covers matter)					Y (akasa is a separate dravya)
MIMAMSA / VEDANTA	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	
CARVAKA	Y	Y	Y	Y	-- NO --	^^^^^^^^^ the empty cell that carries the whole epistemology

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** One empty cell, and it is not an accident of cosmology. *Ākāśa* is refused for exactly the reason inference and testimony are refused: it is not perceived, it is **inferred**. The elemental ledger is therefore the neatest possible demonstration that Cārvāka metaphysics is epistemology applied. This visual answers the first half of the 2020 fifteen-marker on its own.

1. The bridging principle — ontology follows epistemology

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta state the derivation in a single sentence: "The Cārvāka theory of reality **follows from** the epistemological conclusion just discussed. If perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

ANALYSIS: **The principle, formalised for the answer script:**

- P1. Only perception is a pramana. (epistemology)
P2. Ontological commitment should not outrun the reach of the pramanas one accepts. (bridging principle)

C. Only perceptible entities may be admitted as real. (ontology)

ANALYSIS: **P2 is doing enormous work and is rarely noticed by candidates.** It is not a truth of logic. An opponent could accept P1 and yet hold that reality exceeds knowledge — that there are unknowable realities. Cārvāka refuses that gap: for him, what cannot in principle be presented in perception has no claim to be admitted. Naming P2 explicitly, and observing that it is a *presupposition* rather than a proof, is exactly the kind of move that separates a 60% script from an 80% script.

2. The four bhūtas

FACT: **The transmitted sūtra:** *pr̥thivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — "earth, water, fire and air are the elements." And the second: *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — "bodies, senses and objects" are the results of the different combinations of these elements.

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta add the biological consequence explicitly: "Not only non-living material objects but also **living organisms**, like plants and animal bodies, are composed of these four elements, by the combination of which they are produced and to which they are **reduced on death**." There is no separate vital principle and no separate psychic substance.

FACT: Sharma adds the ontological refinement that many candidates miss: "**The elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution.**"

ANALYSIS: **This is a significant doctrinal point.** Cārvāka is not a philosophy of universal flux. The material elements are permanent; only configurations arise and perish. That gives Cārvāka a stable ontological substrate — and it is why the school is classified as a **realist** materialism rather than as a scepticism. It also sharpens the contrast with Buddhism (Subtopic 6) and with Jainism (Subtopic 8).

3. Why ākāśa is rejected — the 2020 question's first half

FACT: **The argument, in four steps.**

1. Earth, water, fire and air are each **perceptible**: they present themselves through manifest sensible qualities — solidity, fluidity, heat and light, motion and touch.
2. *Ākāśa* is **not** perceived as an entity. Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; **it has to be inferred**." Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred."
3. The inference in question is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika one: sound (*śabda* as a quality) is a quality; every quality must inhere in a substance; sound is not a quality of earth, water, fire, air, *ātman*, *manas*, time or space; therefore there is a ninth-listed substance, *ākāśa*, as its unique substrate.
4. Since inference is not a *pramāṇa*, that argument cannot establish anything. Hence the world is composed of **four** elements.

ANALYSIS: **The exchange in table form**, which is what a 15-marker needs:

Move	Position
Vaiśeṣika	FACT: Sound is heard; qualities require substrates; by elimination the substrate is <i>ākāśa</i> , which is one, eternal, all-pervading and imperceptible

Move	Position
Cārvāka	FACT: The hearing of sound is perceptual; the <i>substrate</i> is not. The move from quality to imperceptible substance is an inference and inherits the whole <i>vyāpti</i> problem
Vaiśeṣika rejoinder	ANALYSIS: Then sound is left without a bearer, and the doctrine that qualities inhere in substances is broken
Cārvāka reply	ANALYSIS: Either sound is a state of the perceptible air-medium, or the demand for a bearer is itself a metaphysical prejudice; positing an imperceptible substrate is an unnecessary multiplication
Assessment	ANALYSIS: The Cārvāka is consistent, and the cost is real: he must either naturalise sound into the air or abandon the substance–quality framework that his own four-element realism assumes

ANALYSIS: **The self-critical point that earns the highest marks on this question.** The Cārvāka accepts the four elements as *substances*. But if he accepts the substance–quality scheme for earth, water, fire and air, he cannot simply refuse it for sound without argument. His most defensible line is therefore **not** "qualities need no substrates" but "sound is a modification of perceptible air", which is a naturalising move rather than a sceptical one. Saying this shows you have thought past the textbook.

4. Consciousness from matter — *bhūta-caitanya-vāda*

FACT: **The transmitted sūtra:** *kiṇvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — "consciousness [arises] from matter as the intoxicating power [arises] from fermenting agents."

FACT: **The problem the doctrine answers.** Chatterjee and Datta pose the objection sharply: "we do not perceive consciousness in **any** of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?"

FACT: **The Cārvāka reply — the emergence thesis and its two canonical analogies.**

Analogy	The ingredients	The novel property	The point made
Betel (tāmbūla)	Betel leaf, lime and areca nut — "none of which is originally red"	A reddish tinge, "when chewed together"	A property may appear in a combination that is present in no ingredient separately
Fermentation	Molasses (<i>guḍa</i>), "originally non-intoxicant"	Intoxicating power, "when allowed to ferment"	The same substance under a different condition may develop qualities originally absent

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta draw the conclusion: "In a similar way, it is possible to think that the material elements combined in a particular way give rise to the conscious living body. **Consciousness is an epiphenomenon or bye-product of matter**; there is no evidence of its existence independent of the body." Sharma reports the same doctrine and quotes the striking Western formulation used of it: "Matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."

ANALYSIS: **Read the two analogies carefully, because they are not the same argument.**

BETEL : combination of DIFFERENT ingredients -> new quality
(structural / compositional emergence)

FERMENTATION: the SAME ingredient under a NEW CONDITION -> new quality
(processual / transformational emergence)

Together they block two different objections:

- (i) "consciousness is in none of the elements" -> betel answers it
- (ii) "the elements are the same before and after" -> fermentation answers it

ANALYSIS: **The explanatory gap, stated honestly — and this is what distinguishes a philosophical answer from a report.** Both analogies establish that **novel observable qualities** can arise from combination. Consciousness, however, is not an observable third-person quality like redness or intoxicating power. It is the *condition of observation itself* — subjective, first-personal, and, as Sharma notes, **private** in a way redness is not: consciousness "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". The analogies therefore establish emergence of the wrong logical type.

ANALYSIS: **The Cārvāka's best available reply**, which a fair answer must supply: positing an immaterial soul does not close the gap either — it **renames** it. To say "consciousness arises because there is a conscious substance" explains nothing that "consciousness arises from a specifically organised living body" does not; the dualist has bought a word, not an explanation. ANALYSIS: Assessment: the reply neutralises the dualist's claim to explanatory superiority without discharging the Cārvāka's own explanatory debt. Both sides face the gap; only one side pretends to have crossed it.

5. Why no God is needed — the pot-and-potter exchange and svabhāvavāda

FACT: **The objection, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact form.** "Can the material elements by themselves give rise to this wonderful world? We find that even the production of an object like an earthen jar requires, in addition to **clay** which is its **material cause**, a **potter** who is the **efficient cause**, that shapes the material into the desired form. The four elements supply only the material cause of the world. Do we not require an efficient cause, like God, as the shaper and designer?"

FACT: **The Cārvāka reply.** "The material elements themselves have got each its **fixed nature (svabhāva)**. It is by the natures and laws inherent in them that they combine together to form this world. There is thus no necessity for God. **There is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design.** They can be explained more reasonably as the fortuitous products of the elements."

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta then supply the three technical labels, all of which should appear in a 10-marker on Cārvāka metaphysics:

Label	Sanskrit	Meaning	Textbook wording
Naturalism	<i>svabhāvavāda</i>	The world is explained "only by nature"; things behave by their own inherent natures	FACT: "Insofar as this Cārvāka theory tries to explain the world only by nature, it is sometimes called naturalism"
Mechanism / accidentalism	<i>yadṛcchāvāda</i>	Denies conscious purpose behind the world; explains it as "a mere mechanical or fortuitous combination of elements"	FACT: "It is also called mechanism (<i>yadṛcchā-vāda</i>)"
Positivism	—	Believes "only in positive facts or observable phenomena"	FACT: "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called positivism "

ANALYSIS: **Note carefully for the 2024 question:** the label "positivism" is not an examiner's invention or a modern imposition. It is applied to Cārvāka **by the standard textbook itself**, and with a stated reason. That is a decisive evidential point for Subtopic 9 and for the workbook's 2024 answer — although, as we shall see, the label still needs heavy qualification.

ANALYSIS: **A refinement on svabhāvavāda that strengthens any answer.** *Svabhāva* is invoked twice in Cārvāka, at two different points, and they must not be confused:

(1) EPISTEMOLOGICAL USE : "why is fire always hot and water cool?"
 -> because of their inherent natures; no supernatural principle is needed, AND "there is neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future."
 (Chatterjee & Datta)

(2) COSMOLOGICAL USE : "who arranged the world?"
 -> nothing did; the elements combine by their own natures; no designer is required.

ANALYSIS: Use (1) is a **deflationary** appeal: "nature" is a label for observed regularity, deliberately not an explanatory power, and the Cārvāka refuses to guarantee its persistence. Use (2) is a **substantive** appeal: nature is doing real cosmological work in place of God. The obvious objection — that "nature" is an empty word unless analysed — bites hard on use (2) and hardly at all on use (1). Separating them is the most sophisticated move available in this subtopic.

6. How many materialisms? Sadānanda's fourfold classification

FACT: Sharma records, from Sadānanda's *Vedāntasāra*, that **four** different materialist schools were distinguished by their identification of the self:

Variant	The self is identified with	Sanskrit
1	The gross body	<i>sthūla śarīra</i>
2	The senses	<i>indriya</i>
3	The vital breaths	<i>prāṇa</i>
4	The mental organ	<i>manas</i>

FACT: Sharma adds: "All the schools agree in regarding the soul as a **product of matter**." He also records Śāntarakṣita's report that the materialist *Kambalāśvatara* held that consciousness arises out of the material body **associated with vital breaths**.

ANALYSIS: **Exam value.** This single table shows that "Cārvāka" names a **family** of materialist positions, not a monolith. It supports the source-caution of Subtopic 1, it forestalls the objection that the school was crude and undifferentiated, and it gives you a precise, citable internal differentiation almost no other candidate will have.

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Cārvāka materialism is not modern scientific materialism, and saying why is worth marks.**

Axis	Cārvāka	Modern scientific materialism
Basic entities	FACT: Four perceptible gross elements	Unobservable micro-entities: fields, particles, forces
Attitude to inference	FACT: Denies it <i>pramāṇa</i> -status	Depends on it absolutely — theory is inference from data
Attitude to unobservables	FACT: Refuses them as unwarranted	Admits them freely when they earn their explanatory keep
Method	ANALYSIS: Polemical minimalism	Experiment, prediction, controlled testing, revision
Status of laws	ANALYSIS: <i>Svabhāva</i> , with no guarantee of future uniformity	Law-like regularities, projectible and quantified

ANALYSIS: **The resulting paradox, which is the best single sentence in this subtopic:** *Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas modern materialism reaches a materialist conclusion by a thoroughly inferential route. The agreement in ontology conceals a total disagreement in method.* That sentence is the pivot of any good answer on whether Cārvāka is "scientific" or "positivistic".

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ *Bhūta-caitanya-vāda* is an early statement of what is now called **emergent physicalism**, and the objection pressed above — that redness and intoxicating power are third-person properties whereas consciousness is first-personal — is recognisably the modern **explanatory gap** objection. ANALYSIS: This is a conceptual parallel offered for one clause of comparative framing. It is not a dated development, it carries no authority, and in a Paper I script it must never displace *bhūta*, *caitanya*, *svabhāva* and the betel and fermentation analogies.

UPSC traps

1. FACT: **Four elements, not five.** This is the single most examined factual trap in the topic.
2. FACT: Do not say Cārvāka "does not know of" *ākāśa*. He knows the Vaiśeṣika argument for it and rejects it, precisely because it is inferential.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not say Cārvāka denies the reality of sound. He denies the inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not say the elements are impermanent. Sharma: "the elements are eternal, but their combinations undergo production and dissolution."
5. ANALYSIS: Do not present the betel and fermentation analogies as one analogy. They answer two different objections — compositional and transformational emergence.

6. ANALYSIS: Do not claim the analogies solve the problem of consciousness. State the explanatory gap **and** the Cārvāka's reply that dualism merely renames it.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not translate *svabhāvavāda* as "scientific naturalism". It is a metaphysical refusal of teleology, not an experimental programme.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not forget *yadṛcchāvāda*. The denial of purpose is a distinct thesis from the affirmation of inherent natures, and the two sit together somewhat uneasily.
9. ANALYSIS: Do not treat "Cārvāka" as one uniform doctrine. The *Vedāntasāra* records four materialist identifications of the self.

Revision notes

- FACT: **Bridging principle**: ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *pramāṇas*. Name it as a presupposition, not a proof.
- FACT: *prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — four elements; and *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- FACT: Living bodies too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- FACT: **The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish** (Sharma).
- FACT: *Ākāśa* is rejected "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika sound-to-substrate inference is refused.
- FACT: *kiṇvātibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- FACT: **Betel** = compositional emergence (leaf, lime, nut -> red). **Fermentation** = transformational emergence (*guḍa* -> intoxicant).
- FACT: Consciousness is an "epiphenomenon or by-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile."
- ANALYSIS: **Explanatory gap**: redness and intoxication are third-person properties; consciousness is private and first-personal. The Cārvāka's best reply is that the soul-hypothesis renames the gap rather than closing it.
- FACT: **Pot-and-potter**: the objector needs an efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with *svabhāva* and denies that design is proved.
- FACT: Three labels from the textbook: **naturalism** (*svabhāvavāda*), **mechanism** (*yadṛcchāvāda*), and **positivism** ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").
- ANALYSIS: Separate the **deflationary** use of *svabhāva* (regularity, with no guarantee of future uniformity) from the **substantive** cosmological use (nature in place of God).
- FACT: *Vedāntasāra*: four materialist schools identify the self with gross body, senses, vital breaths, or *manas*.
- ANALYSIS: Cārvāka's materialism is anti-inferential; modern materialism is thoroughly inferential. Same conclusion, opposite method.

MCQ 9

Why does the Cārvāka accept earth, water, fire and air while rejecting *ākāśa*?

- A. Because the first four are perceptible through their manifest sensible qualities, whereas *ākāśa* is established only by an inference — from sound to an imperceptible substrate — and inference is not admitted as a *pramāṇa*.
- B. Because *ākāśa* is accepted only by the Jainas, and Cārvāka's polemic is directed exclusively against Jainism.
- C. Because *ākāśa* is impermanent while the other four elements are eternal.
- D. Because *ākāśa* is a quality rather than a substance, and Cārvāka admits only substances.

FACT: **Correct answer: A.** Both textbooks state it in the same terms — Chatterjee and Datta: the Cārvākas "reject ether, because its existence cannot be perceived; it has to be inferred"; Sharma: "he rejects the fifth, the ether, because it is not perceived but inferred." B is historically false: *ākāśa* is a *dravya* for Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, Sāṃkhya, Jainism and Vedānta alike. C inverts the doctrine — *ākāśa* is classically **eternal** and all-pervading. D misdescribes the Vaiśeṣika category scheme, in which *ākāśa* is a substance and sound is its quality.

MCQ 10

The betel analogy and the fermentation analogy are both used to defend *bhūta-caitanya-vāda*. What distinct objection does each answer?

- A. Both answer the same objection, namely that consciousness cannot be perceived.
- B. The betel analogy answers the objection that consciousness is present in none of the four elements taken separately, by showing that a combination may exhibit a property absent from every ingredient; the fermentation analogy answers the objection that the elements are unchanged before and after, by showing that the same material under a different condition may develop a quality originally absent.
- C. The betel analogy establishes that consciousness is red, and the fermentation analogy that it is intoxicating.
- D. The betel analogy is Nyāya's, and the fermentation analogy is Cārvāka's.

FACT: **Correct answer: B.** Chatterjee and Datta give the two cases with exactly this division of labour: betel leaf, lime and nut, "none of which is originally red", acquire a reddish tinge when chewed together; and "even the **same** thing placed under a **different condition** may develop qualities originally absent", as molasses becomes intoxicant on fermenting. A collapses two distinct arguments; C is a category confusion; D misattributes both, since the analogies are transmitted as Cārvāka's own — indeed the fermentation case appears in the transmitted *Bṛhaspati sūtra kinvādibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam*.

FACT: Subtopic 5 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now derive the ontology from the epistemology, argue the *ākāśa* question in both directions, deploy both emergence analogies with their distinct functions, and state *svabhāva* without over-claiming. Proceeding to the self — the highest-value subtopic in the whole item.

Progress: 6 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Self, Body and Consciousness — *Dehātmanvāda*, and Cārvāka versus Buddhist *Anātman* (2024, 20 marks)

[illegible]

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

□ Book context: Carvaka.md §2.3, §2.4 and §3.2 (the Cārvāka–Buddhism comparison table) read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III.2 ("There is no Soul"), including *caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* and the first-person judgements, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §IV, containing the full battery of anti-materialist objections — swoon, dreamless sleep, dream-consciousness, subject–object asymmetry, the two horns of a bull, privacy — read directly; paper -1/indian/Buddhism.md §§3.1–3.5 and §7 on *pañcaskandha*, *santāna*, *pudgala-nairātmya* and the explicit Cārvāka contrast, read directly.

□ CA Search: "personal identity, self and the mind–body problem in Indian philosophy — developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ The contemporary debate over physicalism and personal identity is used only as an explicitly labelled conceptual link.

[illegible]

□□ VISUAL — Three ways of denying the transcendental self (they are not the same denial)

THE QUESTION: what am I?

NYAYA / VEDANTA (the target)

```
+-----+
|  ATMAN  |
| permanent |
| substance |
| OWNER of |
| states   |
+-----+
  ^
  |
states inhere
in a substance
```

CARVAKA

```
+-----+
|  BODY   |
| qualified |
| by con-  |
| sciousness|
+-----+
  ^
  |
"caitanya-
visista deha
eva atma"
  |
SUBSTANCE
RETAINED --
relocated to
the BODY
  |
no rebirth,
no karma
(death = end)
```

BUDDHISM

```
+-----+
| (no owner)|
+-----+
| | | |
rupa vedana
samjna samskara
vijnana
(5 skandhas)
  |
a causal STREAM
(santana), no
substance, but
REAL continuity
  |
SUBSTANCE
ABOLISHED
  |
rebirth WITHOUT
a self; karma
preserved
```

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** This single diagram is the answer to the 2024 twenty-marker. Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into a process. One keeps a bearer and changes its nature; the other removes the bearer altogether. The moral and soteriological consequences then diverge completely: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral story at death, while Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to keep the moral story running without an owner.

1. Dehātmavāda — the doctrine stated exactly

FACT: **The transmitted formula:** *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ* — "the person is the body qualified by consciousness"; and, in Chatterjee and Datta's rendering of the Cārvāka position, "What people mean by a soul is nothing more than this **conscious living body** (*caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā*)."

ANALYSIS: **Read the formula carefully — every word is load-bearing:**

CAITANYA-VISISTA	: QUALIFIED BY CONSCIOUSNESS -> not any body; the LIVING body
KAYAH	: THE BODY -> the perceptible material organism
PURUSAH / ATMA	: IS the person / IS the self -> identity, not correlation

ANALYSIS: **Three misreadings to avoid**, each of which has sunk otherwise good answers:

1. It is **not** "the self is the corpse". The self is the *living, conscious* body; consciousness is the qualifier that makes a body a self.
2. It is **not** "there is no self". There is a self; it is material. Cārvāka is not an eliminativist about persons.
3. It is **not** "consciousness is identical with any one element". Consciousness belongs to the **organised** body-complex, as the emergence analogies establish.

2. The argument for dehātmavāda

FACT: **Step 1 — the negative argument.** "The non-material soul is **never perceived**" (Chatterjee and Datta). What internal perception delivers is a state, not a substance behind the state.

FACT: **Step 2 — the positive argument from ordinary first-person judgements.** This is the Cārvāka's most distinctive and most quotable move: "we have **direct evidence of the identity of the self with the body** in our daily experiences and judgments like, 'I am fat,' 'I am lame,' 'I am blind.' If the 'I', the self, were different from the body, these would be **meaningless**."

ANALYSIS: **The logic of the argument from first-person statements, reconstructed:**

1. In ordinary speech, bodily predicates are attached directly to "I":
I am fat; I am lame; I am blind; I am hungry; I am tall.

2. Predication of this kind is intelligible only if the SUBJECT and the BEARER of the predicate are the same thing.
3. If "I" named an immaterial soul, "I am fat" would be a CATEGORY MISTAKE -- as odd as "the number seven is blue".
4. But these statements are not category mistakes; they are the ordinary currency of self-description.
5. Therefore "I" refers to the body.

ANALYSIS: The dualist's standard reply, and the Cārvāka's rejoinder. The dualist answers that such expressions are **figurative** — the soul speaks of *its* body as a person speaks of "my house". The Cārvāka's rejoinder is that the figurative reading is a **theory-driven reinterpretation** of language, adopted only to save a doctrine that has no independent perceptual support; and that "my body" and "I am lame" are not on a par, since no one says "my body is lame, therefore I am figuratively lame" in the natural course of speech. **ANALYSIS: Assessment:** the argument does not *prove* materialism, but it correctly shifts the burden onto the dualist to explain why ordinary self-ascription runs the way it does.

FACT: Step 3 — the argument from covariation. The authored knowledge file records the standard supporting evidence: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness. Consciousness tracks the states of the body with a fidelity that would be inexplicable if it belonged to something else.

FACT: Step 4 — the consequence. Chatterjee and Datta: "If the existence of a soul apart from the body is not proved, there is no possibility of proving its immortality. On the contrary, **death of the body means the end of the individual**. All questions about previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell, therefore, become **meaningless**."

ANALYSIS: Note the word Chatterjee and Datta use twice: *meaningless*, not merely false. That is a quasi-verificationist register, and it is a genuine evidential asset for the 2024 "positivism" question — though it must be used carefully, since the Cārvāka has no explicit theory of meaning.

3. The objections — Sharma's full battery, and the Cārvāka's replies

ANALYSIS: This is the richest objection-set in Indian philosophy, and reproducing four or five of these with replies is what turns a 12/20 into an 16/20. Sharma sets them out at length; each is paired below with the best available Cārvāka answer.

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
1	Self-consciousness. If consciousness means <i>self</i> -consciousness, it cannot be identified with the living body, since animals have living bodies without rational consciousness	ANALYSIS: Only a particular combination of elements, obtaining in the human body, produces consciousness; so no counter-example arises from animals	ANALYSIS: Sharma calls this "wrong": it makes consciousness essential to a specific organisation, which invites objection 2
2	Separability. If consciousness were an essential property of the living body it would be inseparable from it. But "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen without consciousness"	ANALYSIS: These are states in which the relevant <i>organisation</i> is disrupted; the property is essential to the organisation, not to bare bodily existence	ANALYSIS: Strong reply, but it moves the doctrine from "body" to "functional organisation", which is a real concession
3	Dream-consciousness. "In dreams, consciousness is seen without the living body"; the dreamer on waking disowns the dream-body but owns the dream-consciousness	ANALYSIS: The dreaming subject is the sleeping physical body; the dream-body is imagined content, not a second body	ANALYSIS: The reply is decent; Sharma's inference that consciousness therefore "persists through" waking, dream and deep sleep already presupposes the Vedāntic three-state argument
4	Subject-object asymmetry. "The subject, the knower, cannot be reduced to the object, the known, since all objects presuppose the existence of the subject"; the subject is enjoyer, the object enjoyed	ANALYSIS: A material organism can be both knower and known, as a hand can touch itself; asymmetry of <i>role</i> does not entail difference of <i>substance</i>	ANALYSIS: This is the deepest objection and it is not fully answered; it is the ancestor of the modern subjectivity problem

#	Objection (Sharma)	Best Cārvāka reply	Residual pressure
5	Co-existence is not causation. "The eye cannot see in darkness. Sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight"; "the two horns of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related." The body may be the instrument of consciousness, not its cause	ANALYSIS: Correct as logic — but the instrument-hypothesis needs an independent user, and no such user is perceived; the materialist hypothesis is the more economical of two unproven options	ANALYSIS: Genuinely undecided; both sides are arguing from the same evidence to different best explanations
6	Imperceptibility of the alleged property. "If consciousness is a property of the body, it must be perceived like other material properties. But it is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard "	ANALYSIS: It is perceived — by internal perception, which Cārvāka admits	ANALYSIS: But then the Cārvāka's own criterion has been stretched: internal perception delivers something with no external sensory mode, which is precisely the anomaly the dualist is pointing at
7	Privacy. A material property "should be known by all in the same manner and should not be private. But we find that consciousness is intimately private and consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others"	ANALYSIS: Privacy is explained by the <i>locality</i> of the organism: each body has its own internal states, as each fire has its own heat	ANALYSIS: The reply confuses <i>causal locality</i> with <i>epistemic inaccessibility</i> ; the objection retains real force
8	Self-manifestation regress. If consciousness is a property of the body, "why should the body, qualified to produce consciousness, itself stand in need of being manifested by consciousness?"	ANALYSIS: Being a producer of awareness and being an object of awareness are different roles, and one thing may play both	ANALYSIS: A fair reply, though it again concedes a role-distinction that dualists exploit
9	Symmetry of ignorance. "If the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its non-existence too cannot be so demonstrated"	ANALYSIS: The Cārvāka's principle is asymmetrical by design: the burden lies on the one who <i>posits</i> an entity, not on the one who withholds assent	ANALYSIS: This exposes the difference between <i>not asserting</i> and <i>denying</i> , and most doxographies attribute outright denial rather than agnosticism to Cārvāka

ANALYSIS: **The single most useful evaluative sentence to carry from this table:** *Sharma's objections 2, 3 and 5 show that the Cārvāka's evidence establishes at most a dependence of consciousness on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the materialist's own evidence.* That sentence is worth reproducing in any answer on the Cārvāka self.

4. Memory and personal identity

ANALYSIS: **The objection.** Memory reaches across time: I remember what I did. What sustains the "I" through the constant replacement of bodily material? A permanent substance seems required.

ANALYSIS: **The three answers on the table, and the exam requires you to distinguish them:**

School	What secures the identity of the rememberer
Nyāya / Vedānta	FACT: A permanent <i>ātman</i> which is the single owner of past experience and present memory
Cārvāka	ANALYSIS: Bodily-psychological continuity: the same living organism persists, so the same organism that experienced now recalls. Memory is a bodily-mental trace in a continuing body
Buddhism	FACT: <i>Santāna</i> , the causal stream; memory belongs to the same causal continuum, reinforced by <i>pratisandhāna</i> (relinking), and in Yogācāra by <i>ālaya-vijñāna</i> carrying <i>bījas</i>

ANALYSIS: **The comparative point that examiners reward.** Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject the permanent owner, but they replace it with different things: Cārvāka with a **material continuant** (a body that endures), Buddhism with a **causal continuant** (a stream in which nothing endures). The Cārvāka answer is metaphysically cheaper and psychologically thinner; the Buddhist answer is metaphysically subtler and must work much harder, which is why it develops *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and eventually *ālaya-vijñāna*.

5. Solved PYQ — 2024, Q6(a), 20 marks: Cārvāka versus Buddhist rejection of ātmā

FACT: Exact question. "Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of ātmā."

ANALYSIS: Demand decoding. The directive is *differentiate*. The examiner is testing whether the candidate knows that two denials of *ātman* can be philosophically opposite. The commonest failure is a script that says "both deny the soul" and then describes each separately. That earns the marks of a definition, not of a comparison.

ANALYSIS: The comparison matrix — the core of the answer:

Axis	Cārvāka	Buddhism
Formal name of the doctrine	FACT: <i>Dehātmavāda</i> — the body is the self	FACT: <i>Anātman</i> / <i>nairātmyavāda</i> — no self-substance
What is denied	FACT: That the self is a transcendental, immaterial, separable category	FACT: That there is any permanent, unchanging, substantial self at all
What is affirmed in its place	FACT: A material self: <i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i>	FACT: Five <i>skandhas</i> — <i>rūpa</i> , <i>vedanā</i> , <i>saṃjñā</i> , <i>saṃskāra</i> , <i>vijñāna</i> — with no owner
Underlying ground of the denial	FACT: Epistemological : the soul is never perceived, and perception alone is a <i>pramāṇa</i>	FACT: Ontological–soteriological : <i>pratītyasamutpāda</i> and <i>kṣaṇikavāda</i> leave no room for a permanent entity; and belief in self generates <i>trṣṇā</i> and <i>duḥkha</i>
Status of consciousness	FACT: An epiphenomenon , a by-product of the organised body	FACT: <i>Vijñāna</i> is one <i>skandha</i> among five — conditioned, momentary, not a product of matter
Is a substance retained?	FACT: Yes — substance is relocated into matter	FACT: No — substance is abolished ; only process remains
Continuity across time	ANALYSIS: Bodily-psychological continuity of one organism	FACT: <i>Santāna</i> , the causal stream; <i>pratisandhāna</i> ; <i>ālaya-vijñāna</i> in Yogācāra
Chariot / analogies	ANALYSIS: Betel and fermentation — emergence of a novel quality	FACT: The chariot : "chariot" is a name for an arrangement of parts; so is "person"
Rebirth	FACT: Rejected — death is the end of the individual	FACT: Accepted — rebirth without a transmigrating self
Karma	FACT: Rejected as an unseen moral force	FACT: Accepted as causal-moral continuity across the stream
Liberation	FACT: No mokṣa ; "death alone is liberation" (<i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>)	FACT: Nirvāṇa is the central soteriological goal
Ethical consequence	ANALYSIS: This-worldly prudence; <i>kāma</i> and <i>artha</i>	FACT: The eightfold path; compassion; extinction of craving
Internal foil within the tradition	ANALYSIS: Sadānanda's four materialist identifications: body, senses, <i>prāṇa</i> , <i>manas</i>	FACT: Puggalavāda (Vātsīputrīyas): a <i>pudgala</i> neither identical with nor different from the <i>skandhas</i> — criticised by the mainstream as a relapse into self-theory

ANALYSIS: The four differentiating theses to state explicitly — this is the part that converts the table into an answer:

1. **DIFFERENT TARGETS.** Carvaka denies a **TRANSCENDENTAL** self and substitutes a **MATERIAL** one. Buddhism denies a **SUBSTANTIAL** self of ANY kind, material or immaterial -- so the Buddhist critique applies to Carvaka's body-self as well.
2. **DIFFERENT GROUNDS.** Carvaka's ground is **EPISTEMIC** (unperceived). Buddhism's ground is **ONTOLOGICAL** (dependent origination and momentariness) and **SOTERIOLOGICAL** (self-belief generates craving).
3. **DIFFERENT AFTERMATHS.** Carvaka's denial **TERMINATES** the moral

narrative at death. Buddhism's denial is engineered **PRECISELY** to preserve karma and rebirth without an owner.

4. **DIFFERENT METAPHYSICAL PRICES.** Carvaka must explain how matter yields subjectivity. Buddhism must explain how a stream without an owner yields memory, responsibility and liberation.

ANALYSIS: Model conclusion for the 20-marker. *Both schools reject the ātman, but the rejections are not species of a single genus. Cārvāka's is a reductive relocation of the self into perceptible matter, driven by an epistemic restriction and terminating in mortality; Buddhism's is a dissolution of substance into a conditioned process, driven by dependent origination and terminating in nirvāṇa. Indeed the Buddhist analysis refutes Cārvāka as decisively as it refutes Nyāya, since a body-self is still a self. The correct verdict is that Cārvāka denies the transcendence of the self while retaining its substantiality; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity.*

□ **Advanced refinement**

ANALYSIS: The point almost no candidate makes, and it is decisive. Buddhism's *anātman* is **not** a weaker version of Cārvāka's denial; it is a **wider** one. *Rūpa* — material form — is itself one of the five *skandhas*, and is expressly declared not to be self. The Buddhist analysis therefore rules out the Cārvāka's body-self *by name*. Writing this sentence demonstrates that you understand the doctrines rather than the labels: *for the Buddhist, "I am this body" is one of the very identifications that anātman is formulated to dismantle.*

ANALYSIS: A second refinement: the Puggalavāda foil. The authored Buddhism file records that some Buddhists, associated with the Vātsīputrīyas, posited a *pudgala* "neither the same as nor different from the *skandhas*", and that the mainstream criticised this as a relapse towards self-theory. **ANALYSIS:** Use this to show that the pressure to preserve a bearer of moral continuity was felt *inside* Buddhism, and was refused — which makes the contrast with Cārvāka, who simply keeps a bearer and makes it material, doubly instructive.

□ **Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)**

□ The Cārvāka–Buddhist–Nyāya triangle is the Indian version of the contemporary three-cornered debate between **substance dualism, reductive physicalism and bundle or process theories of the self**. **ANALYSIS:** Note it in a clause if it helps frame the answer; it is a conceptual parallel only, not a dated development, and the Sanskrit vocabulary must carry the answer.

UPSC traps

1. **FACT: Never write that Cārvāka and Buddhism deny the self "in the same way".** This is the exact error the 2024 question was designed to catch.
2. **ANALYSIS:** Do not say Cārvāka denies the self *simpliciter*. He denies a transcendental self and affirms a material one.
3. **ANALYSIS:** Do not say Buddhism reduces the person to the body. *Rūpa* is only one of five *skandhas*, and is itself denied selfhood.
4. **ANALYSIS:** Do not say Cārvāka denies consciousness. He denies that consciousness needs an immaterial bearer.
5. **ANALYSIS:** Do not omit *saṁtāna* when handling memory in Buddhism; and do not smuggle a soul into it.
6. **ANALYSIS:** Do not present Sharma's objections as unanswerable. Give the Cārvāka's reply and *then* assess.
7. **ANALYSIS:** Do not miss the asymmetry point: Cārvāka's denial ends the moral narrative; Buddhism's denial is constructed to continue it.
8. **ANALYSIS:** Do not forget the first-person statements — "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind". They are the Cārvāka's own positive argument and are frequently omitted.
9. **ANALYSIS:** Do not treat "death alone is liberation" as a serious soteriology. It is a *rejection* of soteriology expressed in soteriological vocabulary.

Revision notes

- **FACT:** *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness.
- **FACT:** Negative argument: "the non-material soul is **never perceived**."

- FACT: Positive argument: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — bodily predicates attach directly to "I"; on dualism they would be meaningless.
- FACT: Covariation: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease alter awareness.
- FACT: Consequence: death of the body is the end of the individual; questions of rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- FACT: **Sharma's objections**: swoon and dreamless sleep (body without consciousness) · dreams (consciousness without body) · subject cannot be reduced to object · co-existence is not causation (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is neither smelt, tasted, seen, touched nor heard · consciousness is **private** · non-existence of the soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ANALYSIS: Best evaluative line: the evidence establishes **dependence**, and dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.
- FACT: Memory: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *ātman*; Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity; Buddhism invokes *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and *ālaya-vijñāna*.
- FACT: **2024 contrast in one line**: Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process.
- FACT: Cārvāka's ground is epistemic; Buddhism's is ontological (*pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds craving).
- FACT: Cārvāka rejects rebirth, karma and *mokṣa*; Buddhism retains rebirth, karma and *nirvāṇa* without a self.
- ANALYSIS: *Rūpa* is one of the five *skandhas* — so Buddhist *anātman* refutes the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
- ANALYSIS: **Puggalavāda** (Vātsīputrīya) is the internal Buddhist foil; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** are the internal Cārvāka foil.

MCQ 11

Which statement most precisely differentiates the Cārvāka refutation of the self from the Buddhist rejection of *ātmā*?

- Cārvāka denies the self on soteriological grounds, while Buddhism denies it on purely epistemological grounds.
- Cārvāka accepts rebirth without a soul, while Buddhism denies rebirth altogether.
- Cārvāka denies the **transcendence** of the self but retains a substantial bearer by identifying the self with the living body, whereas Buddhism denies **substantiality** as such — including the body-self, since *rūpa* is itself one of the five *skandhas* — and replaces the bearer with a causal stream that preserves karma and rebirth.
- Both deny the self for identical reasons, differing only in the technical vocabulary they employ.

FACT: **Correct answer: C.** The authored Buddhism file states the point directly: Cārvāka "denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction", while Buddhism "denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body". A reverses the grounds — Cārvāka's is epistemic, Buddhism's ontological and soteriological. B inverts both positions on rebirth. D is precisely the error the 2024 question was set to detect.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 12

C. D. Sharma objects that "in swoons, fits, epilepsy, dreamless sleep etc. the living body is seen without consciousness", and that "the eye cannot see in darkness; sight is not possible without light, yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight." What do these two objections, taken together, establish against the Cārvāka?

- That consciousness is a fifth element alongside earth, water, fire and air.
- That perception is not a valid source of knowledge.
- That consciousness cannot exist at all in a living body.
- That the Cārvāka's own evidence establishes at most that consciousness **depends** on the body, and dependence is compatible with the body being the instrument rather than the cause of consciousness — so the materialist conclusion is under-determined by the evidence offered for it.

FACT: **Correct answer: D.** The first objection attacks the claimed inseparability of consciousness from the living body; the second severs the inference from constant co-occurrence to causation — Sharma adds that "the two horns

of a bull which are always found together cannot be regarded as causally related", concluding that "the body is a mere **instrument** for the manifestation of consciousness and cannot be regarded as its cause." A invents a doctrine no school holds in this form. B would be a Jayarāśi-style objection, not Sharma's argument here. C is absurd.

FACT: Subtopic 6 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You now hold the highest-value comparison in this syllabus item, together with the full objection-and-reply battery. Proceeding to the systematic rejection of transcendent entities.

Progress: 7 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: The Rejection of Transcendent Entities — God, Soul, *Karma*, Rebirth, Heaven, *Mokṣa*, Veda and Ritual

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

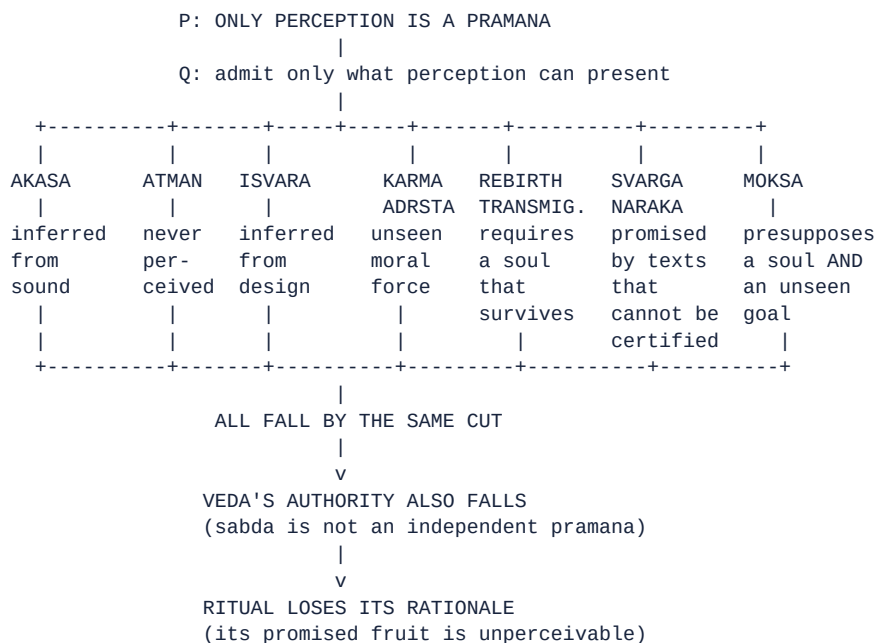
□ Book context: Carvaka .md §2.1, §2.5, §2.6 and the restored dossier on transmigration read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §III.2–3 and §IV ("Ethics"), including the *śrāddha*, *jyotiṣṭoma* and traveller's-food reductions, read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §II ("Sources"), including the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary of the Cārvāka position on the Agnihotra, the three Vedas and the "three authors of the Vedas", read directly; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md consulted for the exact 2020 Q6(b) and 2021 Q5(e) wording.

□ CA Search: "religious scepticism, critiques of ritual authority and transcendental entities — Cārvāka, developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ Contemporary scientific scepticism about unfalsifiable claims is noted at the end as a labelled *conceptual* parallel only, without any evidential or news status.

[illegible]

□ □ VISUAL — The demolition tree: one premise, seven casualties



ANALYSIS: **Caption.** This tree is the answer to the 2021 ten-marker in diagram form. The examiner's phrase — "the **bearing** of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities" — asks for exactly this: not a list of denials, but the demonstration that a single epistemic cut severs them all at once.

1. The general form of every Cārvāka denial

ANALYSIS: Every denial in this subtopic instantiates one template. Learn the template, not the list.

1. X is claimed to exist.
2. X is not, and cannot in principle be, presented in perception.
3. The only routes to X are inference or scriptural testimony.
4. Neither inference nor testimony is an independent pramana.
5. Therefore there is no valid means by which X could be known.

6. Therefore X should not be admitted into our ontology.

ANALYSIS: **The precision point at step 6.** There is a real difference between *withholding assent* (agnosticism) and *denying* (atheism, in the broad sense). □ The doxographical sources overwhelmingly present Cārvāka as **denying** — "the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism" (Chatterjee and Datta) — but the argument as stated licenses only the weaker conclusion. Sharma records the opposing school's exploitation of exactly this gap: "if the existence of the soul surviving death cannot be demonstrated, its **non-existence** too cannot be so demonstrated." A first-class answer notes the gap and states which reading it is defending.

2. God — and why *svabhāvavāda* is the operative reason

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "God, whose existence cannot be perceived, **fares no better than the soul**. The material elements produce the world, and the supposition of a creator is unnecessary."

ANALYSIS: **Two distinct arguments are at work, and separating them is worth marks:**

Argument	Form	Force
Epistemic	God is imperceptible; the only routes to God are inference (the design and causal arguments) and <i>śabda</i> ; both are denied <i>pramāṇa</i> -status	FACT: Removes the warrant for theism
Explanatory (<i>svabhāvavāda</i>)	Even granting the explanatory question, the fixed natures of the elements suffice; "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design"	FACT: Removes the need for theism

ANALYSIS: Note that the second argument is logically independent of the first, and is the more interesting one, because it engages Nyāya on Nyāya's own ground. Nyāya's *kāryāt* inference argues from the world as a composite **effect** to an intelligent efficient cause. The Cārvāka's *svabhāvavāda* rejoinder does not merely say "you cannot know that"; it says "the explanandum is discharged without you". ANALYSIS: Chatterjee and Datta record the further Cārvāka move: the objects of the world "can be explained more reasonably as the **fortuitous** products of the elements" — which is *yadr̥cchāvāda*, and which sits in some tension with a strong *svabhāvavāda* that grounds regularity in fixed natures. Noting that internal tension is a genuinely advanced observation.

3. Karma, *adr̥ṣṭa* and the moral order

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta name *adr̥ṣṭa* explicitly among the casualties: "God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and **any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*)** cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

ANALYSIS: **Why *adr̥ṣṭa* is the decisive test case.** *Adr̥ṣṭa* — "the unseen" — is by its own definition imperceptible. It is the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Mīmāṃsā device for connecting an act performed now with a fruit enjoyed later, sometimes in another life. The Cārvāka's objection is therefore not incidental but **definitional**: an entity whose name announces its imperceptibility is precisely what an epistemology of perception must refuse.

FACT: **The objection from moral order, and the Cārvāka's reply.** The authored knowledge file records the exchange: without *karma* and rebirth, moral order is said to collapse. The Cārvāka answer is that "morality need not be underwritten by cosmic bookkeeping; human pain, pleasure, prudence, and social consequences are enough for practical conduct."

ANALYSIS: **Assessment to write.** The reply establishes that a *this-worldly* account of moral motivation is available; it does not establish that such an account can support obligations that run against self-interest with no observer. This is the enduring weak point of Cārvāka ethics and connects directly to Subtopic 8.

4. Rebirth and transmigration — the 2020 question's second half

FACT: **Exact question (2020, Q6(b), 15 marks).** "*Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of Ākāśa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul.*"

ANALYSIS: **What transmigration requires, and where Cārvāka cuts each requirement:**

Requirement of transmigration	Cārvāka's cut
(a) A self distinct from the body	FACT: <i>Dehātmavāda</i> : the self is the living body; no separable subject exists to migrate
(b) Survival of that self after bodily death	FACT: "Death of the body means the end of the individual"; the elements disperse, and the combination that carried consciousness is dissolved
(c) A carrier of moral desert across the gap	FACT: <i>Karma</i> and <i>adṛṣṭa</i> are unperceived and hence unwarranted
(d) Knowledge that any of (a)–(c) obtains	FACT: Only scripture and inference could supply it; both are denied <i>pramāṇa</i> -status
(e) Meaningfulness of the claim	ANALYSIS: Chatterjee and Datta report that questions about "previous life, after-life, rebirth, enjoyment of the fruits of actions in heaven or hell" become meaningless — a quasi-verificationist step

ANALYSIS: The critical evaluation the question explicitly demands. A "critically evaluate" question is not answered by exposition. Supply both sides:

STRENGTHS of the Carvaka position

- (i) consistency: the same criterion cuts akasa, atman and rebirth alike
- (ii) economy: nothing unobservable is posited
- (iii) anti-exploitation: it removes the machinery on which ritual prescription and priestly authority rested
- (iv) it forces every rival school to say HOW an unseen bearer of desert is known -- a demand Nyaya answers only inferentially

WEAKNESSES

- (i) the argument rests on the rejection of inference, which is itself vulnerable (Subtopics 3-4)
- (ii) dependence of consciousness on the body does not entail production by the body (Sharma's instrument objection)
- (iii) "not established" is slid into "does not exist"
- (iv) the disappearance of moral continuity leaves desert and obligation without any ground beyond prudence
- (v) Sharma: the non-existence of a surviving soul is as undemonstrable as its existence

ANALYSIS: Verdict formula for this question: *The rejection of ākāśa and of transmigration are the same argument applied twice — once to cosmology and once to soteriology — and their force is exactly the force of the underlying epistemology. Where that epistemology is defensible, as a demand that metaphysical postulates earn their keep, the rejection is powerful; where it over-reaches, in converting "unestablished" into "unreal", the rejection outruns its warrant.*

5. Heaven, hell and mokṣa

FACT: **Heaven.** Chatterjee and Datta: the Mīmāṃsakas hold that the highest goal is heaven (*svarga*), "a state of unalloyed bliss that can be attained hereafter by performing here the Vedic rites. **The Cārvāka rejects this view, because it is based on the unproved existence of a life after death.** 'Heaven' and 'hell' are the **inventions of the priests** whose professional interest lies in coaxing, threatening and making people perform the rituals. Enlightened men will always refuse to be duped by them."

FACT: **Liberation.** The Cārvāka argument is a dilemma, and it is elegant:

What could "liberation" mean?

HORN 1: freedom of the SOUL from bondage to physical existence
-> "absurd, because there is no soul"

HORN 2: attainment, IN THIS LIFE, of a state free from ALL pain
-> "an impossible ideal. Existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain."

RESIDUE: "Liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean DEATH." -> maranam eva apavargah

FACT: Both horns and the residue are given verbatim in substance by Chatterjee and Datta, and the residue is one of the six transmitted *Bṛhaspati sūtras*.

ANALYSIS: **How to present maraṇam eva apavargaḥ without caricature.** It is not a recommendation of death and it is not nihilism. It is a **reductio of the concept of liberation**: if *mokṣa* means the total cessation of suffering, then the only state that satisfies the definition is the one no wise person would work for. The verse is a critique of the *coherence* of the goal, not an endorsement of dying. Saying this in one sentence is worth a mark and protects you from the commonest misreading in the topic.

6. The Veda, priestcraft and the ritual reductions

FACT: **The epistemic charge.** *Śabda* is not an independent *pramāṇa* (Subtopic 2); Vedic authority therefore has no certified standing. Claims of authorlessness or infallibility are not perceptually available.

FACT: **The sociological charge.** Chatterjee and Datta report it plainly: "in reality the Vedas are the works of some **cunning priests** who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous", and the tangible benefit of the rites goes to "the priests who officiate and enjoy the emoluments."

FACT: **The Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha summary**, as reproduced by Sharma, is the sharpest form of the polemic and should be used with an explicit source-caution: "There is no heaven, no final liberation, nor any soul in another world; nor do the actions of the four castes, orders etc. produce any real effect. The **Agnihotra**, the three Vedas, the ascetic's three staves and smearing one's self with ashes, were made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness... **(All the ceremonies are) a means of livelihood (for) Brāhmaṇas. The three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons.**"

FACT: **The three ritual reductions** — each is a genuine argument, not merely abuse, and each has the same logical shape: *take the ritual's own premise seriously, and derive an absurdity the practitioner will not accept.*

#	The reductio	The premise it tests	The absurdity generated
1	The śrāddha argument. If the food offered at the funeral ceremony can appease the hunger of the departed, "what is the use of a traveller's taking food with him? Why should not his people make some offerings in his name at home to satisfy his hunger?"	That an offering here nourishes a person elsewhere	ANALYSIS: Nourishment at a distance would make travel provisions pointless — a consequence no one accepts
2	The upstairs argument. "Food offered on the ground floor should satisfy a person living upstairs."	The same, in miniature	ANALYSIS: A vivid <i>reductio</i> of action-at-a-distance nourishment
3	The jyotiṣṭoma argument. "If the priests really believe, as they say, that the animals killed at a sacrifice are sure to reach heaven, why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents instead of animals and make heaven sure for them?"	That ritual slaughter secures heaven for the victim	ANALYSIS: The priest's refusal reveals that he does not believe his own premise — an argument from revealed preference

ANALYSIS: **The philosophically important observation to add.** The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is not a joke; it is an early and powerful use of **revealed preference** as evidence about belief. It says: your unwillingness to apply your doctrine where it would cost you shows that you do not hold it in the way you profess. That is a serious epistemic argument and deserves to be presented as one.

ANALYSIS: **The balance an answer must strike.** Chatterjee and Datta themselves describe the Cārvākas as raising "cheap laughter at the customary rites". An answer that reproduces only the abuse looks unserious; an answer that reproduces only the epistemology misses the school's historical bite. Present the polemic **and** extract the argument inside it.

7. Solved PYQ — 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

FACT: **Exact question.** "Comment on the bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities by them."

ANALYSIS: **Demand decoding.** The key word is **bearing** — the examiner wants the *derivation*, not two separate lists. A script that describes the epistemology in one paragraph and the denials in another has not answered the question, however accurate each paragraph is.

ANALYSIS: **Model answer (≈160 words).**

For Cārvāka, ontology is the shadow cast by epistemology. Perception alone is a *pramāṇa*: *anumāna* fails because *vyāpti* can be established neither by perception (all cases are never surveyed), nor by inference (*petitio principii*), nor by testimony (whose own validity is inferred); and *śabda* fails because words certify only that something was said. Chatterjee and Datta accordingly state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "**follows from**" this epistemological conclusion.

The bearing is immediate and systematic. *Ākāśa* falls because it is inferred from sound, not perceived. *Ātman* falls because no soul is ever perceived apart from the living body. *Īśvara* falls because he is reached only by design-inference, and *svabhāva* discharges the explanatory work. *Karma*, *adṛṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *mokṣa* fall because each is either an unseen force or a post-mortem state that no perception could present. Vedic authority falls with *śabda*, and ritual loses its rationale with it.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict to append if space allows:** the derivation is impeccably consistent; its cost is that the epistemic premise is itself vulnerable, so the entire ontology stands or falls with the rejection of inference.

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Cārvāka's atheism is structurally different from every other Indian denial of God, and this comparison is high-value in Paper I and Paper II alike.**

School	Denies a creator God because	Accepts anumāna?	Accepts scriptural authority?
Cārvāka	FACT: No <i>pramāṇa</i> establishes him, and <i>svabhāva</i> suffices	WRONG: No	WRONG: No
Sāṃkhya	FACT: <i>Prakṛti</i> explains evolution; a God is superfluous and would compromise <i>puruṣa</i> 's inactivity	FACT: Yes	FACT: Yes
Mīmāṃsā	FACT: The Veda is <i>apauruṣeya</i> and <i>apūrva</i> matures without a dispenser	FACT: Yes	FACT: Yes — supremely
Jainism	FACT: The world is uncreated; karma is material and self-operating; but godhood is attained by the liberated soul	FACT: Yes	WRONG: Rejects Vedic authority
Buddhism	FACT: Dependent origination explains arising; an immutable cause cannot yield succession	FACT: Yes	WRONG: Rejects Vedic authority

ANALYSIS: **The resulting single sentence, which is worth memorising:** *Cārvāka is the only Indian school whose atheism is generated by its epistemology rather than by its cosmology or its soteriology — which is why it also rejects the karma, rebirth and liberation that Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain.* Non-theism is common in Indian philosophy; **this-worldliness is Cārvāka's alone.**

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ The demand that a postulate be in principle checkable, and the treatment of unfalsifiable claims as unwarranted rather than merely unproved, is conceptually parallel to modern **scientific scepticism** and to verificationist criteria of meaning. ANALYSIS: Offer this as a labelled conceptual parallel only, and be careful: the parallel is exactly what makes the 2024 "positivism" question tempting *and* what makes an unqualified "yes" to it wrong, since Cārvāka rejects the very inferential machinery on which modern science runs.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not present the denials as a list. Show the **derivation** from the single epistemic premise — that is what "bearing" means in 2021 Q5(e).
2. ANALYSIS: Do not slide from "not established" to "does not exist" without noticing. Sharma exploits exactly that slide.

3. ANALYSIS: Do not read *marāṇam eva apavargaḥ* as a recommendation of death. It is a *reductio* of the concept of liberation.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce the ritual criticisms to abuse. The *śrāddha* and *jyotiṣṭoma* arguments are genuine *reductios*, and the second is an argument from revealed preference.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not quote the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* invective without a source-caution; it is a summary preserved by an opponent.
6. ANALYSIS: Do not say "Cārvāka is the only atheist school in India". Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are all non-theistic. Cārvāka is the only school whose atheism follows from its **epistemology** and which also discards karma, rebirth and liberation.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not forget *adr̥ṣṭa* by name. It is the perfect test case, since its name means "the unseen".
8. ANALYSIS: Do not miss the internal tension between *svabhāvavāda* (fixed natures grounding regularity) and *yadr̥cchāvāda* (fortuitous combination). Noting it is a mark of independent thought.

Revision notes

- FACT: **The template:** X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is a *pramāṇa* -> X is unwarranted -> X is rejected.
- ANALYSIS: Note the gap between withholding assent and denying; the doxographies attribute denial, the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- FACT: God falls twice over: **epistemically** (no *pramāṇa*) and **explanatorily** (*svabhāva* suffices; "no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design").
- FACT: *Adr̥ṣṭa* is named explicitly among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*)".
- FACT: Transmigration requires a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three; Cārvāka cuts every one.
- FACT: Heaven and hell are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* is rejected because it rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- FACT: **The liberation dilemma:** freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) or freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain); residue — *marāṇam eva apavargaḥ*.
- FACT: **Three ritual reductios:** *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs for a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* and "why not sacrifice their own old parents".
- FACT: *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes are "the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons" — quote with a source-caution.
- ANALYSIS: The *jyotiṣṭoma* argument is an argument from **revealed preference** about what the priest actually believes.
- ANALYSIS: Cārvāka is not the only non-theistic Indian school; it is the only one whose atheism is generated **epistemologically**, and the only one that also discards karma, rebirth and *mokṣa*.
- ANALYSIS: Internal tension worth noting: *svabhāvavāda* grounds regularity in fixed natures, while *yadr̥cchāvāda* calls the world's objects "fortuitous products".

MCQ 13

What is the precise sense of the transmitted Cārvāka *sūtra marāṇam eva apavargaḥ*, "death alone is liberation"?

- A. It is a *reductio* of the concept of *mokṣa*: if liberation means freedom of a soul there is no soul to free, and if it means a state free from all pain then embodiment cannot supply it — so the only state satisfying the definition is death, which no wise person would pursue.
- B. It is a positive soteriology recommending suicide as the highest human goal.
- C. It asserts that the soul attains liberation at the moment of death, as in Jainism.
- D. It means that liberation is attained by ritual performance at the time of death.

FACT: **Correct answer: A.** Chatterjee and Datta set out the dilemma exactly: if liberation is freedom of the soul from bondage to physical existence "it is absurd because there is no soul", and if it is a pain-free state in this very life "it is

also an impossible ideal", since "existence in this body is bound up with pleasure as well as pain" — hence "liberation in the sense of complete cessation of sufferings can only mean death". They add that "no wise man would willingly work for that end". B is the caricature the *reductio* is designed to expose. C attributes a soul the school denies. D restores the ritual efficacy the school rejects.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer.**

MCQ 14

Which statement best identifies what is distinctive about Cārvāka's rejection of God among the Indian schools?

- A. Cārvāka is the only Indian school that does not accept a creator God.
- B. Cārvāka's rejection is generated by its **epistemology** — no *pramāṇa* establishes God, and *svabhāva* discharges the explanatory work — whereas Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism reject a creator on cosmological, exegetical or soteriological grounds while retaining inference, karma, rebirth and liberation.
- C. Cārvāka rejects God but retains *adṛṣṭa* as the impersonal moral law.
- D. Cārvāka rejects God because the Veda, correctly interpreted, is atheistic.

FACT: **Correct answer: B.** Non-theism is widespread in Indian philosophy — Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all deny a creator — which makes A false. What is unique to Cārvāka is the epistemological route and the accompanying rejection of *karma*, rebirth and *mokṣa*, which the other non-theistic schools retain. C is false: Chatterjee and Datta name "any unperceived law (like *adrṣṭa*)" among the entities rejected. D is false: Cārvāka rejects Vedic authority outright rather than reinterpreting it.

FACT: Subtopic 7 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now derive every denial from the single epistemic premise, evaluate the transmigration critique on both sides, and present the ritual polemic as argument rather than abuse. Proceeding to ethics and the social meaning of the school.

Progress: 8 / 9 | Stage: Advanced | Subtopic: Ethics and the Political-Social Meaning — and Cārvāka versus Jaina Reality (2020, 15 marks)

[illegible]

□ Book context: Carvaka .md §2.7, §2.9 and §4.3 read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §IV ("Ethics") and §V ("Conclusion") — including the *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction, Vātsyāyana's refined hedonism, the sixty-four fine arts, the king-as-God report and the incorporation of *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* — read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §V ("Ethics") and §IV, including the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* "debt and ghee" verse and the *anekāntavāda* material in Chapter Four, read directly; paper -1/indian/Jainism.md §§1.1–1.7 and §4.3 read directly for the 2020 comparison.

□ CA Search: "hedonism, secular ethics and this-worldly value theory in Indian philosophy — Cārvāka, developments February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. □ Contemporary secular and naturalistic ethics are noted at the end only as a labelled conceptual parallel.

□ □ VISUAL — The *puruṣārtha* ledger, and the two axes of the Cārvāka position

THE FOUR PURUSARTHAS		CARVAKA'S VERDICT
DHARMA	(virtue / duty)	-----> REJECTED : "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted"
ARTHA	(wealth)	-----> ACCEPTED as MEANS, not as end
KAMA	(enjoyment)	-----> ACCEPTED as THE END
MOKSA	(liberation)	-----> REJECTED : obtainable "only by death, and no wise man would work for that"

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+-----+
| ARTHA ---- means ----> KAMA |
|                               |
+-----+

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AND WITHIN "KAMA" THERE ARE TWO CARVAKAS:

DHURTA (cunning/crude)	SUSIKSITA (cultured/refined)
-----	-----
gross sensual pleasure	pleasure disciplined by the
immediate gratification	sixty-four fine arts, self-
egoistic hedonism	control and urbanity
the caricature the	Vatsyayana's Kama-sutra as the
opponents preserved	"best positive evidence"
	(Chatterjee & Datta)

ANALYSIS: **Caption.** Two axes, not one. The first axis is which *puruṣārthas* survive; the second is *what kind of* hedonist is doing the surviving. Almost every weak answer collapses the second axis and presents only the *dhūrta*. The textbooks themselves refuse that collapse.

1. The doctrine, stated exactly

FACT: **The transmitted sūtra:** *kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — "enjoyment is the only end of human life."

FACT: **The four-fold verdict**, in Chatterjee and Datta's exact terms: "Of these four, the Cārvāka rejects the last two. Liberation in the sense of destruction of all sufferings can be obtained only by death and no wise man would willingly work for that end. **Virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted.** Therefore neither liberation nor virtue should be our end. Wealth and enjoyment are the only rational ends that a wise man can toil to achieve. But **enjoyment is the ultimate end; wealth is not an end in itself, it is good only as a means to enjoyment.**"

ANALYSIS: **Two things to notice, both examinable.**

1. The rejection of *dharma* is **epistemically** driven, not merely appetitive. *Dharma* is rejected because it is a *scriptural* category and *śabda* is not a *pramāṇa* — the same cut that removed *ākāśa* and *ātman*. Writing "Cārvāka rejects virtue because he loves pleasure" reverses the direction of the argument.
2. *Artha* is subordinated, not co-ordinate. Cārvāka is not a materialist about *wealth*; wealth is instrumental. That is a real ethical thesis and it separates Cārvāka from mere acquisitiveness.

2. The standard of right action, and its consequentialist form

FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "A **good action** is one which leads to a **balance of pleasure** and a **bad action** is one which brings about **more pain than pleasure**. This Cārvāka ethics may be called, therefore, **hedonism** or the theory that pleasure is the highest goal."

ANALYSIS: **The structure of the criterion, made explicit:**

VALUE THEORY	: pleasure is the sole intrinsic good; pain the sole intrinsic evil
NORMATIVE THEORY	: the right action is the one whose balance of pleasure over pain is greatest
SCOPE	: the doxographies present the scope as EGOISTIC -- "pleasure of the senses in this life and that too of the individual is the sole end" (Sharma)
BUT	: Chatterjee & Datta explicitly deny that ALL materialists were egoistic hedonists

ANALYSIS: **The scope question is where the real philosophy is.** Egoistic hedonism and universalistic hedonism share a value theory and differ entirely in their normative consequences. Chatterjee and Datta record the decisive consideration: **"Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline. Life in society is impossible if man does not sacrifice a part of his pleasures for others."** And they immediately supply the evidence that some Cārvākas saw this: "Some Cārvākas, we are told, regard the **king as God**. This implies their great faith in the necessity of society and its head."

3. Refined hedonism — the evidence, and why it matters

FACT: **The dhūrta / suśikṣita distinction.** Chatterjee and Datta: "a distinction found sometimes between the **cunning (dhūrta)** and **cultured (suśikṣita)** Cārvākas makes it likely that the Cārvākas were **not all of the same gross, uncultured type**." Sharma records the same twofold division of "Crude and Refined Materialists".

FACT: **The evidence for refinement**, as Chatterjee and Datta present it:

Evidence	Detail
The fine arts	Materialists "devoted themselves also to the pursuit of more refined pleasures by cultivating, for example, the fine arts, the number of which is as large as sixty-four (<i>catuḥ-ṣaṣṭi-kalāḥ</i>), according to Vātsyāyana"
Political philosophy and economics	" Political philosophy and economy (daṇḍanīti and vārttā) came to be incorporated at some stage in the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas "
The king as God	Reported of some Cārvākas — implying "great faith in the necessity of society and its head"
Vātsyāyana's Kāma-sūtra	"The best positive evidence of refined hedonism is found in the ethical philosophy propounded by Vātsyāyana in the second chapter of the <i>Kāma-sūtra</i> "

FACT: **Vātsyāyana's position, stated precisely — and note the important qualification.** Chatterjee and Datta are careful: "Though Vātsyāyana **believes in God and in life after death** and, therefore, is **not a materialist in the ordinary sense**, yet he may be regarded as one, according to a **wider** sense of the term, namely, one who tries to explain 'higher phenomena by lower ones'." His materialist tendency "consists in holding that *dharma* and *artha* are to be treated only as **means** to enjoyment, which is therefore the supreme end."

FACT: **The content of the refinement**, which is the material that rescues Cārvāka ethics from caricature:

1. Emphasis on **self-control (brahmacharya)**, spiritual discipline (*dharma*) and **urbanity (nāgarika-vṛtti)**, "without which human enjoyment of pleasure is reduced to the level of beastly enjoyment."
2. All *kāma* is "ultimately reducible to the gratification of the five senses"; the satisfaction of the senses is "necessary for the very existence of the body (*śarīra-sthiti*)", like the satisfaction of hunger.
3. The senses "must be **educated, disciplined and cultured** through a training in the sixty-four fine arts", given only after "absolute self-continence and study" in the earlier part of life.
4. Against the impatient hedonist who will not "forgo present comfort" or "undergo any toil for future enjoyment", Vātsyāyana argues that such an attitude "would be **suicidal**", since it "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds in the hope of the future enjoyment of a crop."
5. **"Inordinate desire, inconsistent with the principles of dharma and wealth, leads to ruin and annihilates the chances of all enjoyment."**
6. He argues, "like a modern scientific man, that some science is at the root of every successful practice."

ANALYSIS: **The philosophical upshot, and it is important.** Point 4 is a **prudential** argument *internal* to hedonism: unregulated present gratification is self-defeating **on hedonistic grounds**. That is exactly the structure of Epicurus' argument in the West, and it means that the refined Cārvāka position is not a compromise with morality imported from outside — it is what consistent hedonism requires of itself. Chatterjee and Datta conclude that Vātsyāyana "represents Indian hedonism at its best", and that the name *suśikṣita-cārvāka* was "perhaps" applied to thinkers of this kind.

ANALYSIS: **The honest counterweight.** Sharma's verdict is far harsher and must be carried too: "The ethics of the Cārvāka is a **crude individual hedonism**"; "All values are mere phantoms created by a diseased mind"; and he

locates the school's downfall not in its atheism or its materialism — which it shares with respected schools — but in "the Cārvāka's **denial of all human values** which make life worth living... Sensual pleasure is a very faint shadow of the supreme pleasure. There is a qualitative difference in pleasure. **The pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher.**"

ANALYSIS: **How to adjudicate in an answer.** The two verdicts are about different things and both are usable:

SHARMA'S TARGET : the doctrine as transmitted in the doxographies -- gross, egoistic, quantitative hedonism
 CHATTERJEE & DATTA'S TARGET : the historical breadth of the movement -- the susikṣita strand, the fine arts, dandanīti and varta, the king-as-God report, Vatsyayana's discipline
 VERDICT TO WRITE : the transmitted doctrine is vulnerable to Sharma's "pleasure of the pig" objection because it offers no QUALITATIVE distinction among pleasures; the refined strand supplies a PRUDENTIAL and CULTURAL regulation of pleasure but still no independent standard of value. Carvaka can be made prudent; it cannot easily be made moral.

4. The "debt and ghee" verse — and the source caution

□ **The verse**, as preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* and reproduced by Sharma: **"While life remains let a man live happily, let him feed on ghee (clarified butter) even though he runs in debt; when once the body becomes ashes, how can it ever return here?"**

ANALYSIS: **The source caution, which must accompany every use of this verse.** This is:

1. A verse preserved in a **fourteenth-century doxography** compiled by **Mādhava**, a Vedāntin — that is, by an opponent;
2. Presented in a chapter whose purpose is refutation;
3. Not attributable to any surviving primary Cārvāka text;
4. Frequently paraphrased in exam scripts as *yāvaj jīvet sukhaṃ jīvet*, which the authored knowledge file itself flags as a **doxographical verse associated with the tradition, not a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.**

ANALYSIS: **How to use it correctly in an answer:** *"The often-quoted verse — live happily, feed on ghee even in debt, for the body once turned to ashes does not return — is preserved in the Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha, an opponent's compendium, and should be treated as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit rather than as its own scripture."* That single sentence signals scholarly care and forestalls the examiner's objection.

ANALYSIS: **The philosophical point beneath the rhetoric.** Strip away the polemic and the verse encodes a real argument: *if there is no post-mortem accounting, then the discounting of present goods in favour of future or other-worldly ones is irrational.* That is an argument about the **rationality of deferral under a finite horizon**, and it is answerable — Vātsyāyana himself answers it, in point 4 above, by observing that a refusal to defer would prevent even sowing a crop. Presenting the verse *with* its internal rebuttal is far better than quoting it as a slogan.

5. Positivistic, naturalistic, secular — a first pass at the 2024 label

ANALYSIS: Full treatment belongs to Subtopic 9 and the workbook, but the ethical material contributes three of the strongest points:

Label	Why it fits FACT:	Why it must be qualified ANALYSIS:
Naturalistic	<i>Svabhāva</i> vāda; value grounded in embodied pleasure and pain; no supernatural sanction	The notion of "nature" is descriptive, not analysed into laws
Secular	Morality is detached from scripture and priesthood; <i>daṇḍanīti</i> and <i>vārtā</i> enter the school; the king, not God, is the guarantor of order	The detachment is polemical rather than institutional; no political theory survives

Label	Why it fits FACT:	Why it must be qualified ANALYSIS:
Positivistic	FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply the word themselves: the theory "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena "; they add that the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists "	ANALYSIS: Positivism venerates science , which is built on inference; Cārvāka attacks inference. Positivism has a constructive programme; Cārvāka has a polemical minimalism. And Comte's positivism carries a philosophy of history and a sociology entirely absent here

6. Solved PYQ — 2020, Q7(c), 15 marks: Cārvāka versus Jaina conceptions of reality

FACT: **Exact question.** "Explain the differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism."

ANALYSIS: **Demand decoding.** The axis is **conception of reality** — metaphysics and the epistemology that licenses it — not ethics, and not "materialism versus spirituality" as a slogan. The best answers run four or five explicit axes.

ANALYSIS: **The comparison matrix:**

Axis	Cārvāka	Jainism
Number of <i>pramāṇas</i>	FACT: One — <i>pratyakṣa</i> alone	FACT: Several; knowledge is fivefold — <i>matī, śruta, avadhi, manaḥparyāya, kevala</i>
Basic definition of the real	ANALYSIS: Whatever is perceptible; matter in combination	FACT: <i>Sat</i> = utpāda-vyaya-dhrauṇya — origination, decay and persistence together
Ultimate constituents	FACT: Four <i>bhūtas</i> : earth, water, fire, air	FACT: Six <i>dravyas</i> : <i>jīva, pudgala, dharma, adharma, ākāśa, kāla</i>
<i>Ākāśa</i>	FACT: Rejected — inferred, not perceived	FACT: Accepted as a distinct <i>dravya</i> providing accommodation
Souls	FACT: None; the self is the living body	FACT: Infinitely many <i>jīvas</i> , each intrinsically conscious; consciousness is the soul's inseparable essence , not (as the Cārvākas hold) "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions"
Substance and mode	ANALYSIS: Elements eternal, combinations transient; no developed <i>guṇa-paryāya</i> analysis	FACT: Every <i>dravya</i> has <i>guṇa</i> (essential qualities) and <i>paryāya</i> (modes); the gold-ornament example
Truth and standpoint	ANALYSIS: Single standpoint; no level-distinction at all	FACT: Anekāntavāda — reality is many-faced; nayavāda and syādvāda ; the seven-fold predication
Attitude to universals	ANALYSIS: Denied — Sharma notes the Jaina charge that materialism views "particulars alone as real and universals as unreal"	FACT: Real, though standpoint-conditioned
Karma	FACT: Rejected as an unseen force	FACT: Accepted, and uniquely as subtle material substance adhering to the <i>jīva</i> ; <i>bhāvabandha</i> and <i>dravyabandha</i>
Liberation	FACT: None; <i>marāṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	FACT: <i>Mokṣa</i> through the three jewels and the five <i>mahāvratas</i> ; <i>kevala-jñāna</i>
Overall type	ANALYSIS: Materialist monism of substance, pluralist only about elemental kinds	FACT: Realistic and relativistic pluralism — "common-sense realism and pluralism"
Shared ground	FACT: Both are <i>nāstika</i> — both reject Vedic authority; both are realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God	

ANALYSIS: **The two sentences that lift this answer above a list.**

1. The deepest difference is not materialism versus spiritualism but the number of standpoints each allows: Jainism's *anekāntavāda* multiplies both entities and points of view, while Cārvāka admits a single standpoint and the barest possible furniture — and this is why Jainism can accommodate change and persistence together while Cārvāka must simply assert that the elements are eternal and their combinations are not.
2. Their agreement is as instructive as their disagreement: both are *nāstika*, both are realists about the perceptible world, and both refuse a creator God — so the classification "*nāstika*" tells you almost nothing about a school's metaphysics.

□ Advanced refinement

ANALYSIS: **Was Cārvāka a social philosophy?** Two pieces of evidence, both from Chatterjee and Datta, suggest more than pure appetite: the incorporation of *daṇḍanīti* (political philosophy, the science of governance) and *vārttā* (economics, the science of livelihood) into the philosophy of the Lokāyatikas; and the report that some Cārvākas "regard the king as God". ANALYSIS: The natural reading is a **secular theory of political authority**: order is guaranteed not by cosmic *dharma* or divine sanction but by the sovereign, and prosperity by the productive arts. □ The evidence is thin and doxographical, and must be presented as suggestive rather than established — but it is precisely the material that saves a Cārvāka answer from ending in caricature, and it directly supports the "secular" half of the 2024 label.

ANALYSIS: **A final ethical refinement.** Cārvāka's ethics lacks two things that every rival supplies: a **qualitative** distinction among pleasures (Sharma's "pleasure of the pig") and an account of **other-regarding** obligation. Vātsyāyana supplies a partial answer to the first through cultivation and the fine arts, and Chatterjee and Datta gesture at the second through the necessity of social discipline and the king. But neither is derived from the Cārvāka's own value theory; both are added to it. ANALYSIS: **The honest verdict:** Cārvāka's ethics is a fully coherent theory of *prudence* and an incomplete theory of *morality*.

□ Conceptual link (not a current-affairs item)

□ Cārvāka's grounding of value in embodied pleasure and pain, without supernatural sanction, is conceptually parallel to modern **secular and naturalistic ethics**; and the *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction mirrors the Western contrast between crude and refined, or quantitative and qualitative, hedonism. ANALYSIS: Conceptual parallel only, offered in a clause; not a dated development, and never a substitute for *puruṣārtha*, *kāma*, *artha* and the Sanskrit sources.

UPSC traps

1. ANALYSIS: Do not reduce Cārvāka ethics to reckless sensualism. The textbooks themselves distinguish *dhūrta* from *suśikṣita* Cārvākas.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say Cārvāka rejects *dharma* because he prefers pleasure. He rejects it because it is a **scriptural** category, and *śabda* is not a *pramāṇa*.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *artha* as a second end. It is explicitly a **means** to *kāma*.
4. □ Do not quote the "ghee and debt" verse as Cārvāka scripture. It is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not call Vātsyāyana a Cārvāka without qualification. He "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term".
6. ANALYSIS: Do not omit *daṇḍanīti*, *vārttā* and the king-as-God report if the question touches the school's social or political meaning.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the 2020 Jainism comparison with "materialism versus spirituality". Run the axes: *pramāṇas*, definition of the real, constituents, *ākāśa*, soul, substance–mode, standpoint, karma, liberation.
8. ANALYSIS: Do not forget that Jainism holds consciousness to be the soul's **inseparable essence**, expressly denying the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".
9. ANALYSIS: Do not present Sharma's harsh verdict and Chatterjee and Datta's sympathetic one as a contradiction. They target different objects — the transmitted doctrine and the historical movement.

Revision notes

- FACT: *kāma evaiḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; *artha* is its **means**; *dharma* and *mokṣa* are rejected.

- FACT: *Dharma* is rejected on **epistemic** grounds: virtue and vice are "distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- FACT: Criterion of right action: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- FACT: **Dhūrta** (cunning/crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured/refined) Cārvākas — the textbooks refuse a single, gross portrait.
- FACT: Evidence for refinement: the sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-śaṣṭi-kalāḥ*); *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata; some Cārvākas regard the **king as God**.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism" — but he believes in God and an afterlife and so is a materialist only "in a wider sense".
- FACT: Vātsyāyana's regulation: *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses, and the argument that refusing to defer would prevent even sowing a crop.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is not compatible with social discipline."
- ANALYSIS: Sharma's counterweight: "crude individual hedonism"; the school fell through "the denial of all human values"; "the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."
- □ The "ghee and debt" verse comes from the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* — an opponent's compendium; quote with caution, and extract the argument about deferral under a finite horizon.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply the word **positivism** to Cārvāka themselves — "because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and compare its view of inference to the pragmatists and logical positivists.
- FACT: **2020 comparison**: one *pramāṇa* versus five kinds of knowledge · four *bhūtas* versus six *dravyas* · *ākāśa* rejected versus accepted · no soul versus infinite *jīvas* with consciousness as inseparable essence · single standpoint versus *anekāntavāda* and *syādvāda* · no karma versus **material** karma · no liberation versus *mokṣa* and *kevala-jñāna*.
- ANALYSIS: Shared ground with Jainism: both *nāstika*, both realist about the perceptible world, both reject a creator God.
- ANALYSIS: Verdict: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality**.

MCQ 15

Why, on the Cārvāka's own reasoning, is *dharma* rejected as a *puruṣārtha*?

- Because pleasure is intrinsically more agreeable than duty, and human beings always pursue the more agreeable.
- Because *dharma* was invented by the Jainas and Buddhists, whose authority Cārvāka rejects.
- Because *dharma* is a *scriptural* category — "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted" — so it falls with *śabda*, exactly as *ākāśa* falls with inference.
- Because *dharma* and *mokṣa* are identical, and *mokṣa* is impossible.

FACT: **Correct answer: C.** Chatterjee and Datta give the reason in exactly those words, which shows that Cārvāka ethics is a *consequence* of the epistemology rather than an independent appetite for pleasure. A reverses the direction of the argument and reduces a normative claim to a psychological one. B is historically false — *dharma* is a pan-Indian category and pre-eminently a Vedic one. D conflates two distinct *puruṣārthas* that the sources reject for different reasons.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

MCQ 16

What is the correct scholarly status of the widely quoted line "let a man live happily and feed on ghee even though he runs in debt, for when once the body becomes ashes how can it ever return here"?

- It is the opening *sūtra* of the surviving *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*.
- It is quoted from Vātsyāyana's *Kāma-sūtra*, chapter two.
- It is a canonical Jaina criticism of the Cārvākas, recorded in the *Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya*.

D. It is a verse preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* — an opponent's fourteenth-century doxographical compendium — and must be presented as a doxographical characterisation of the school's spirit, not as a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text.

FACT: **Correct answer: D.** Sharma reproduces the verse within the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha* summary of the Cārvāka position, and the authored knowledge file explicitly directs that such lines be presented "as a traditional doxographical verse associated with the Cārvāka image, not as a securely locatable quotation from an extant primary Cārvāka text." A is impossible, since the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost. B misattributes it; Vātsyāyana's chapter two is the source of the *refined* hedonist material, and indeed argues *against* refusing deferral. C misplaces both the text and the polemical direction.

FACT: Subtopic 8 complete — 2 consecutive correct answers. You can now present Cārvāka ethics without caricature, handle the source-critical problem of its most famous verse, and run the Jaina comparison on the correct axes. Proceeding to the final synthesis.

Progress: 9 / 9 | Stage: Mastery | Subtopic: Comparative Synthesis and Answer-Writing Architecture

[illegible]

PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST

□ Book context: Carvaka.md §§3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8 (inter-school debates, criticisms and replies, traps, keyword bank, PYQ routing and answer architecture) read in full; Chatterjee and Datta, Chapter II §V ("Conclusion") — including the "touchstone" verdict, the Kant–Hume comparison and the pragmatist / logical-positivist parallel — read directly; C. D. Sharma, Chapter Three §§I–V read directly for the counterweight verdict; _PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md read in full for the complete routing table and the ownership frequency data.

□ CA Search: "Cārvāka / Lokāyata — comparative scholarship, positivism debate, February–August 2026"

CURRENT: CA Found: **None in last 6 months.** No credible, dated Cārvāka-specific development falls inside 10 February – 10 August 2026. All four conceptual parallels used across this session — physicalism and emergent consciousness, scientific scepticism, testimonial misinformation, and inference under uncertainty — are explicitly labelled ☐ conceptual links and are **not** presented as current affairs.

[illegible]

MASTER CONCEPT MAP — the whole syllabus item on one page



1. The master comparison table

Axis	Cārvāka	Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika	Buddhism	Jainism
<i>Pramāṇas</i>	FACT: 1 — perception	FACT: 4 — perception, inference, comparison, testimony	FACT: 2 — perception, inference	FACT: Fivefold knowledge; inference admitted
Elements / substances	FACT: 4 <i>bhūtas</i> , no <i>ākāśa</i>	FACT: 9 <i>dravyas</i> , including <i>ākāśa</i> , <i>ātman</i> , <i>manas</i>	ANALYSIS: <i>Dharmas</i> , momentary	FACT: 6 <i>dravyas</i> , including <i>ākāśa</i> and <i>kāla</i>
Self	FACT: Living body (<i>dehātmavāda</i>)	FACT: Eternal substantial <i>ātman</i>	FACT: No self; five <i>skandhas</i> , <i>santāna</i>	FACT: Infinite <i>jīvas</i> ; consciousness their inseparable essence
Consciousness	FACT: Emergent by-product of matter	FACT: Adventitious quality of <i>ātman</i>	FACT: <i>Vijñāna</i> , one conditioned <i>skandha</i>	FACT: Essence of the soul, obscured by karma
God	FACT: Rejected; <i>svabhāva</i> suffices	FACT: Proved by <i>kāryāt</i> , <i>āyojanāt</i> , <i>dhṛtyādeḥ</i> , <i>padāt/śruteḥ</i>	FACT: Rejected; conditions suffice	FACT: No creator; godhood attained by the <i>siddha</i>
Karma	FACT: Rejected as unseen	FACT: Accepted; <i>adṛṣṭa</i> , God as dispenser	FACT: Accepted; causal-moral continuity	FACT: Accepted; karma as subtle matter
Rebirth	FACT: Rejected	FACT: Accepted	FACT: Accepted, without a self	FACT: Accepted
Liberation	FACT: None; <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>	FACT: <i>Apavarga</i> as cessation of pain	FACT: <i>Nirvāṇa</i>	FACT: <i>Mokṣa</i> ; <i>kevala-jñāna</i>
Vedic authority	FACT: Rejected — hence <i>nāstika</i>	FACT: Accepted	FACT: Rejected	FACT: Rejected
Standpoint theory	ANALYSIS: None; single standpoint	ANALYSIS: None	FACT: <i>Saṃvṛti</i> / <i>paramārtha</i>	FACT: <i>Anekānta</i> , <i>naya</i> , <i>syādvāda</i>

2. Criticisms and replies — the consolidated grid

#	Criticism	Cārvāka's best reply	Residual assessment
1	FACT: Self-refutation : the universal denial of inference is itself inferential; other minds and ideas are never perceived	ANALYSIS: Soften the thesis to a denial of <i>apodictic certainty</i> , or restrict it to transcendental inference; or advance no thesis at all (<i>vitāṇḍā</i>)	ANALYSIS: Decisive against the strong form; the softened form survives but is a much weaker doctrine
2	FACT: Science becomes impossible : without induction, no stable knowledge beyond isolated perceptions	ANALYSIS: Practical expectations remain available, tied to future perceptual check	ANALYSIS: Saves practice better than theory; narrows Cārvāka into radical empiricist caution
3	FACT: Perception itself errs (flat earth, static earth, small sun) — and is corrected by inference	ANALYSIS: The corrections are ultimately perceptual and practical; and fallibility about <i>how</i> things appear does not license unperceivable entities	ANALYSIS: Adequate for the flat-earth case, weak for heliocentrism; the hierarchy P over I is genuinely threatened
4	FACT: Emergence does not explain subjectivity : redness and intoxication are public; consciousness is private, and "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard"	ANALYSIS: Positing an immaterial soul renames the gap rather than closing it	ANALYSIS: Both sides face the gap; the Cārvāka at least does not claim to have crossed it
5	FACT: Dependence is not production : light is necessary for sight but is not its cause; the two horns of a bull are constantly conjoined but not causally related	ANALYSIS: The instrument-hypothesis needs a user, and no user is perceived; materialism is the more economical of two unproven options	ANALYSIS: Genuinely undecided; an honest answer says so
6	FACT: Crude hedonism : no qualitative distinction among pleasures — "the pleasure of the pig"	ANALYSIS: The <i>śuśīkṣita</i> strand, the sixty-four arts, and Vātsyāyana's prudential regulation of desire	ANALYSIS: Supplies prudence and culture, not an independent standard of value
7	□ Hostile sources make fair reconstruction impossible	ANALYSIS: Convergence across Buddhist, Advaita, Jaina and Vedāntic doxographies fixes a doctrinal core	ANALYSIS: Use caution without abandoning content
8	ANALYSIS: Same-standpoint inconsistency (Sharma): perception is accepted and inference rejected at the same level, with no <i>vyāvahārika</i> / <i>pāramārthika</i> distinction available	ANALYSIS: Adopt the level-distinction as a repair	ANALYSIS: Effective, but the repair is the interpreter's, not the school's

3. Five verdicts you may safely defend

ANALYSIS: Each of these is defensible, criterion-named and examiner-friendly. Choose according to the question.

1. "Cārvāka's epistemology is more successful as a **critique of certainty** than as a **theory of knowledge**."
2. "Cārvāka's ontology is impeccably derived from its epistemology; its vulnerability is therefore located entirely in that epistemology, not in its metaphysics."
3. "Cārvāka wins the argument that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal, and loses the argument that this abolishes inference as a **pramāṇa** — because Nyāya replaces the demand for omniscient certainty with a demand for disciplined warrant."
4. "Cārvāka denies the **transcendence** of the self while retaining its **substantiality**; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its moral continuity. The two denials are not species of one genus."
5. "Cārvāka is a complete theory of prudence and an incomplete theory of morality; its historical value is critical rather than constructive — it was, as Chatterjee and Datta put it, the **touchstone** on which every other system tested itself."

4. Is Cārvāka positivistic? — the full treatment of the 2024 demand

ANALYSIS: The question ("Do you think Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic in nature? Give reasons and justifications") invites a **graded** answer. A flat yes or a flat no both lose marks. Structure it as three movements.

ANALYSIS: **Movement 1 — establish that the label is not imported by the examiner.** FACT: Chatterjee and Datta apply it themselves: "The Cārvāka theory on the whole may also be called **positivism**, because it believes only in

positive facts or observable phenomena." They also compare its view of inference to that of "the pragmatists and logical positivists". This is a decisive evidential point: you are not being asked to invent a comparison, you are being asked to test one already present in the tradition of exposition.

ANALYSIS: Movement 2 — the case for the label:

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Criterion of the knowable	FACT: Only what is presented in perception	Only what is empirically verifiable
Attitude to metaphysics	FACT: Transcendent entities are rejected as unwarranted	Metaphysical statements are rejected as unverifiable
Attitude to theology	FACT: God and afterlife have no <i>pramāṇa</i>	Theological statements are cognitively empty
Attitude to authority	FACT: Scripture is not an independent source	Revelation is not evidence
Register of dismissal	ANALYSIS: Questions about rebirth and heaven become " meaningless " (Chatterjee and Datta's word)	Unverifiable statements are meaningless
Value theory	FACT: Naturalistic, this-worldly, consequential	Naturalistic and anti-transcendent

ANALYSIS: Movement 3 — the case against, and it is the stronger half:

Respect	Cārvāka	Positivism
Inference	FACT: Denied pramāṇa-status — the fatal divergence	Depends utterly on inference; science <i>is</i> systematised inference
Unobservables	FACT: Refused	Freely admitted when they earn their explanatory keep
Programme	ANALYSIS: Polemical minimalism; no method of confirmation	A constructive programme: unified science, criteria of significance, logical analysis
Tools	ANALYSIS: None of formal logic, semantics or probability	Formal logic, verification and confirmation theory, language analysis
Comte's specific content	ANALYSIS: Absent	Law of three stages, sociology, a philosophy of history
Fallibilism	ANALYSIS: Demands indubitability, then finds nothing meets it	Accepts corrigible, revisable knowledge as the norm

ANALYSIS: **The verdict formula.** *Cārvāka is positivistic in spirit — in its empiricist criterion, its anti-metaphysical temper and its suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance Chatterjee and Datta themselves note. It is not positivistic in method, because positivism is built on the very inference Cārvāka refuses to certify, and possesses a constructive programme that Cārvāka wholly lacks. The safer and more accurate label is radical empiricism or naturalistic materialism; "positivism" is a useful analogy, not a historical identity.* ANALYSIS: Add the paradox from Subtopic 5: Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an anti-inferential route, whereas positivism reaches its conclusions by a thoroughly inferential one.

5. India and the West — convergence and divergence

Western figure or movement	Convergence with Cārvāka ANALYSIS:	Divergence ANALYSIS:
Epicurus / Lucretius	Materialist atomism; this-worldly ethics; freedom from fear of the gods and of death	Epicurus offers <i>ataraxia</i> and a theory of prudent, qualitatively ordered pleasure; Cārvāka as transmitted offers no such refinement — though the <i>suśikṣita</i> strand approaches it
Hume	Induction cannot be rationally justified; causal relation is not perceived	Hume grounds inference in custom and treats it as psychologically indispensable, retaining it as knowledge; Cārvāka denies it <i>pramāṇa</i> -status outright
Logical positivism (Ayer)	Suspicion of unverifiable metaphysics; the "meaningless" register	Ayer preserves scientific inference and analyses meaning through formal tools absent in India
Comte	Rejection of theological explanation in favour of observable phenomena	Comte's positivism is a philosophy of history and a science of society; Cārvāka has neither
Contemporary physicalism	Consciousness as arising from material organisation	Modern physicalism is inference-driven and posits unobservables freely

ANALYSIS: **Chatterjee and Datta's own comparative line, which is safe to quote in substance:** the criticism of inference put in the Cārvāka's mouth "reminds us of similar criticism made in modern times against the soundness of deductive logic", and the Cārvāka view "that no inference can yield certain knowledge is the view of many contemporary Western thinkers like the pragmatists and logical positivists." They also compare the school's fate to that of the Epicureans of Greece, who "have been more hated than understood".

6. Answer architecture

ANALYSIS: **10 marks (≈150 words, 7–8 minutes)**

1 min : thesis -- perception alone is pramana; ontology is its shadow
 4 min : the three doors against vyapti (perception / inference / testimony)
 1 min : ONE sharp addition -- upadhi, or the self-refutation charge
 1 min : verdict linking epistemology to the denial in question

ANALYSIS: **15 marks (≈220–260 words, 12–13 minutes)**

1 min : frame -- Carvaka as the radical empiricist challenge within Indian philosophy, known through hostile doxography
 4 min : full anti-inference argument: vyapti, class-character reply, upadhi, petitio principii
 3 min : the rival's positive case (Nyaya's ladder, or Jaina reality, or the objection set on the self)
 3 min : Carvaka's best reply, and its cost
 1 min : graded verdict with a NAMED criterion

ANALYSIS: **20 marks (≈320–360 words, 17–18 minutes)**

2 min : classify -- epistemology generating metaphysics; note the source problem
 5 min : theory of knowledge in full, with the three doors and upadhi
 4 min : the ontological consequences -- akasa, atman, isvara, karma, moksa
 4 min : the comparison the question demands, run on NAMED AXES
 2 min : two objections with replies and residual pressure
 1 min : criterion-named graded verdict; avoid caricature

7. PYQ routing — the complete 2018–2025 map

Year	Q	Marks	Demand	Session route
2018	Q8(b)	15	Is Cārvāka's rejection of inference acceptable to the other systems? Are they justified?	Subtopics 3 + 4 (three limbs)
2019	Q5(c)	10	Are the Cārvākas consistent in holding that inference is not a source of knowledge?	Subtopic 3 §7
2019	Q6(c)	15	What is wrong, according to the Cārvākas, with the Socrates syllogism?	Subtopic 3 §6
2020	Q6(b)	15	Rejection of <i>ākāśa</i> ; criticism of transmigration	Subtopics 5 §3 + 7 §4
2020	Q7(c)	15	Differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism	Subtopic 8 §6
2021	Q5(e)	10	The bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities	Subtopic 7 §7
2024	Q5(a)	10	Is Cārvāka's philosophy positivistic in nature?	Subtopic 9 §4
2024	Q6(a)	20	Cārvāka's refutation of self versus the Buddhist rejection of <i>ātmā</i>	Subtopic 6 §5
2025	Q5(a)	10	The ground on which Cārvāka rejects inference	Subtopic 3 §§1–5
Cross-link	2022 Q7(c)	15	Nyāya's response to Cārvāka's objections against <i>anumāna</i> (owned by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika)	Subtopic 4

ANALYSIS: **Pattern to notice.** Five of the nine owned parts concern **inference**. Two concern the **self and transcendent entities**. One concerns **comparison with Jainism**, one the **positivism label**. The topic's centre of gravity is unambiguously epistemological — so a candidate who has mastered Subtopics 2, 3 and 4 has covered the majority of the historical demand.

8. Original practice — Mains questions for this session

ANALYSIS: Attempt these under time before consulting the workbook, which contains full model solutions.

- (10) Explain why the Cārvāka rejects *śabda* as an independent *pramāṇa*, and assess whether the rejection is consistent with his acceptance of perception.
- (10) "*Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*." Explain the argument compressed in this Cārvāka *sūtra* and evaluate it.
- (10) Distinguish *svabhāvavāda* from *yadṛcchāvāda* in Cārvāka metaphysics and examine whether they are consistent.
- (15) Examine the Cārvāka doctrine that consciousness is an emergent by-product of the four elements, with the objections it faces.
- (15) "The Cārvāka's *upādhi* objection is a stronger argument than his objection from incomplete enumeration." Critically discuss.
- (15) Assess whether the *dhūrta* / *suśikṣita* distinction rescues Cārvāka ethics from the charge of crude hedonism.
- (15) How far do the surviving sources permit a fair reconstruction of Cārvāka philosophy? Discuss with reference to the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*, the doxographies and the *Tattvopaplavasīmha*.
- (20) "Cārvāka's metaphysics is nothing but its epistemology written out as a list of denials." Critically evaluate.
- (20) Compare the Cārvāka and Nyāya positions on *vyāpti*, and assess whether Nyāya successfully answers the Cārvāka.
- (20) Compare the conceptions of reality in Cārvāka and Jainism, and assess which better accounts for change and persistence.

9. Model philosophical conclusion

ANALYSIS: "Cārvāka is the limiting case of Indian philosophy: the position obtained when a single epistemic restriction — that only what is perceived may be admitted — is applied without exception. Everything else follows. Four elements and not five, because ākāśa is inferred; a body-self and not an ātman, because no soul is perceived; nature and not God, because svabhāva discharges the explanatory work; kāma and not dharma, because virtue is a scriptural category. Its failure is that the restriction cannot be stated without being violated: the denial of inference is itself a universal, and the very act of arguing presupposes the other minds that perception never delivers. Its success is that no Indian school could afford to ignore it. Chatterjee and Datta are right that the Cārvāka became the touchstone on which every system tested its theories, and Sharma is right that materialism, born in discontent, soon died in serious thought. Both verdicts hold, because Cārvāka failed as a system precisely to the degree that it succeeded as a challenge."

Final MCQ 17

Which of the following is the most defensible verdict on the question whether Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic?

- A. It is positivistic in spirit — sharing an empiricist criterion, an anti-metaphysical temper and a suspicion of unverifiable authority, a resemblance the standard textbooks themselves note — but not in method, since positivism is built on the inference Cārvāka refuses to certify and possesses a constructive programme Cārvāka lacks.
- B. It is straightforwardly positivistic, since both hold that only observable phenomena are real.
- C. It is in no sense positivistic, since positivism is a nineteenth-century European movement and no comparison across traditions is legitimate.
- D. It is positivistic because Comte's law of three stages is anticipated in the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra*.

FACT: **Correct answer: A.** Chatterjee and Datta both apply the label — "may also be called positivism, because it believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena" — and supply the material that qualifies it, since they also record the Cārvāka's wholesale denial of inference. B ignores the methodological chasm; C refuses a comparison the tradition of exposition has itself already made; D invents a textual claim about a lost text.

You have **1 consecutive correct answer**.

Final MCQ 18

An examiner writes in the margin of a Cārvāka answer: "You have described the denials. You have not shown the **bearing**." What has the candidate failed to do?

- A. Failed to quote the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*.
- B. Failed to derive each ontological denial from the single epistemic premise that perception alone is a *pramāṇa*, so that *ākāśa*, *ātman*, *Īśvara*, *karma*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *mokṣa* all fall by one cut rather than appearing as a list of separate rejections.
- C. Failed to mention the four elements.
- D. Failed to write in Sanskrit.

FACT: **Correct answer: B.** This is the exact demand of 2021 Q5(e), and it is the organising principle of the entire syllabus item: Chatterjee and Datta state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "follows from the epistemological conclusion". A, C and D are matters of ornament or content, not of the logical architecture the examiner is asking for.

FACT: Learning session complete: 9/9 subtopics. Final assessment passed with 2 consecutive correct answers.

You now hold the source situation, the sole-*pramāṇa* thesis, the full anti-inference argument with its replies, the Nyāya counter-case, the materialist metaphysics with both emergence analogies, the self-comparison with Buddhism, the systematic rejection of transcendent entities, the ethics with its refined strand, and the comparative synthesis with complete PYQ routing.

Commands: Revise · PYQ · Notes · Export PDF

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES — Cārvāka / Lokāyata

Placement note: These register notes come **after** all teaching and practice, and cover **every one of the nine subtopics** taught in this session. They are the last-mile revision layer, not a substitute for the session above.

Register 1 — Sources, names and historical setting

Item	Register entry
Syllabus wording	FACT: "Carvaka : Theory of Knowledge; Rejection of Transcendent Entities" (printed wording retained)
Names	FACT: Cārvāka (<i>carv</i> , to chew / <i>cāru-vāk</i> , sweet-worded) · Lokāyata (<i>lokāyata-mata</i> , view of common people) · Bāṛhaspatya (of Bṛhaspati)
Traditional founder	FACT: Bṛhaspati; his <i>Sūtra</i> is lost; about a dozen <i>sūtras</i> survive as quotations
Transmission	FACT: Known "chiefly" from works that state the views in order to refute them
Sharma's verdict on sources	FACT: "The weak points ... are exaggerated and the strong points are omitted. So we get only a faint caricature and not a true picture"
Key doxographies	FACT: <i>Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha</i> (Mādhava) · <i>Ṣaḍ-darśana-samuccaya</i> (Haribhadra) · <i>Prabodhacandrodaya</i> (a play, Kṛṣṇamīśra) · <i>Tattvasaṃgraha</i> (Śāntarakṣita) · <i>Vedāntasāra</i> (Sadānanda)
Only surviving text	FACT: <i>Tattvopaplavasīmha</i> , Jayarāsi Bhaṭṭa , c. 8th century CE, published Baroda 1940 — but he attacks perception too and admits not even the elements
Six transmitted <i>sūtras</i>	FACT: four elements · bodies-senses-objects from combination · consciousness as intoxicating power · <i>caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ</i> · <i>kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ</i> · <i>marāṇam eva apavargaḥ</i>
<i>Nāstika</i> — exact sense	FACT: Rejects the authority of the Veda (primary sense); also denies life after death (secondary sense); <i>nāstika</i> in both
Historical anchors	FACT: Ajita Kesakambalī (<i>Majjhima Nikāya</i> ; believed only in perception and four elements) · Pūraṇa Kassapa · Makkhali Gosāla · Saṅjaya Belaṭṭhiputta (<i>Sāmaññaphala-sutta</i>)
Causes of its rise (Sharma)	FACT: Protest against monkdōm and ritual externals; Upaniṣadic idealism unsuited to commoners; exploitation and social crisis
Two standing verdicts	ANALYSIS: Chatterjee–Datta: the school was the touchstone of every system · Sharma: "Born in discontent, it soon died in serious thought"
Mnemonic	MEMORY: ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO — one <i>pramāṇa</i> , four elements, two <i>puruṣārthas</i> , zero transcendent entities

Register 2 — Epistemology

- FACT: **Thesis:** *pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda* — perception alone is a *pramāṇa*.
- FACT: "The entire philosophy of the Cārvākas may be said to depend **logically** on their epistemology" (Chatterjee and Datta).
- FACT: **The standard demanded:** knowledge "about which we can have no doubt" and "which must be true to reality".
- FACT: **Both** external (*bāhya*) and internal (*mānasa*) perception are admitted.
- FACT: Consciousness **is** established by perception; what is denied is the inference from consciousness to an immaterial bearer.

- FACT: **The concession:** "in life we very often act unsuspectingly on inference" — but "truth is not an unfailing character of all inferences; it is only an **accident**, and a **separable** one."
- ANALYSIS: **Laukika / vyāvahārika** inference (corrigible, perceptually redeemable) versus **alaukika / pāramārthika** inference (structurally uncheckable). The second is the real target.
- FACT: **Śabda in five steps:** words are heard, hence perceived -> what they *mean* is unperceived -> acceptance runs through "this authority is reliable; all reliable authority should be accepted" -> that is inference -> hence testimony is "as precarious as inference".
- FACT: **The Veda:** "the works of some cunning priests who earned their living by duping the ignorant and the credulous".
- FACT: Sharma's reductio: if testimony proved *vyāpti*, "none would be able to infer anything by himself".
- ANALYSIS: **One template kills the rest:** *upamāna*, *arthāpatti* and *anupalabdhi* each require an unperceived universal.
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's same-standpoint charge:** Śūnyavāda and Advaita reject the *ultimate* validity of **all** *pramāṇas* including perception while retaining empirical validity; the *vyāvahārika / pāramārthika* distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka", so accepting perception and rejecting inference at one level is "a thoughtless self-contradiction".
- MEMORY: **Ledger to reproduce:** Cārvāka 1 · Vaiśeṣika and Buddhism 2 · Sāṃkhya-Yoga 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa and Advaita 6.

Register 3 — The critique of inference

- FACT: Inference is "a leap in the dark"; some inferences are true only "accidentally".
- FACT: The attack targets the **major premise** (*vyāpti*), never syllogistic form.
- FACT: **Door 1 — perception:** all cases past, present and future can never be surveyed.
- FACT: **The class-character (sāmānya) exchange:** even *dhūmatva* cannot be perceptually known, since not all smokes are perceived; and a universal-to-universal relation does not license a particular-to-particular inference. "The difficulty of passing from particulars to the universal ... remains here as before."
- FACT: **Door 2 — inference:** *petitio principii* or regress. Sharma: "Induction is uncertain and deduction is argument in a circle. The logicians, therefore, find themselves stuck up in the mud of inference."
- FACT: A **causal** relation is only a species of invariable relation and inherits the same defect.
- FACT: **Door 3 — testimony:** its own validity is inferred; and if inference depended on testimony, no one could infer by himself.
- FACT: **Upādhi:** the wet-fuel condition — one who infers **smoke from fire** errs, because fire is attended with smoke only where fuel is wet. Unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may always remain hidden".
- ANALYSIS: *Upādhi* is a problem of the **right variable**, not of sample size — which is why more observation alone cannot answer it, and why Nyāya must bring in *tarka*.
- FACT: **2019 Socrates syllogism:** the form is granted; "All men are mortal" is the *vyāpti*; it fails the three doors; the deduction merely re-states an unestablished universal.
- FACT: **Self-refutation (Sharma):** the denial is itself a universal; thoughts, ideas and other minds are never perceived; "the self-refuted Cārvāka position is called sheer nonsense and no system of philosophy".
- ANALYSIS: **Three replies:** *vitaṇḍā* / no-thesis · softened certainty-thesis (strongest) · level-distinction (a repair, not a historical doctrine).
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's tu quoque:** flat earth, static earth, small solar disc — perception errs and is corrected *by inference*; and mere sensation is not knowledge "unless conception or thought has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data" (*Tattvasaṅgraha*).
- MEMORY: **Verdict formula:** the Cārvāka may be **consistent** or **radical**, but not both.

Register 4 — The Nyāya defence

- FACT: **The eight-stage ladder:** *bhūyodarśana* -> *upādhi*-elimination -> *tarka* -> *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* -> *vyāptigraha* -> *liṅga-darśana* -> *parāmarśa* -> *anumiti*.
- FACT: **Anvaya** (wherever *hetu*, there *sādhya*) and **vyatireka** (where no *sādhya*, no *hetu*) — the joint method; systematic search for negative cases, not mere counting.
- FACT: **Upādhi** is a condition that pervades the *sādhya* but not the *hetu*; a defective universal is **restated** at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel".
- FACT: **Tarka** is *pramāṇa-anugrāhaka*, not a *pramāṇa*: it assumes the contradictory and exhibits *aniṣṭa-prasaṅga*, removing the doubt that blocks *vyāptigraha*.
- FACT: **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa**: the universal is presented through the particular — Nyāya's direct answer to the class-character objection.
- FACT: **Parāmarśa**: the cognition of the mark as qualified by concomitance is the *karaṇa* of *anumiti* — hence, for Nyāya, no "leap" occurs at all.
- FACT: **Nirvikalpaka / savikalpaka**: determinate perception is already conceptually qualified, so the Cārvāka's "pure given" is either pre-cognitive or not pure.
- ANALYSIS: **The decisive move**: replace **omniscient certainty** with **disciplined rational warrant**. "The Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice."
- ANALYSIS: **Honest residue**: *tarka* proves nothing alone; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* presupposes realism about universals; only **suspected** *upādhis* can be eliminated.
- FACT: **Cross-school survey (2018 Q8(b))**: Nyāya, Sāṃkhya-Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism all retain inference; Advaita retains it *vyāvahārika*ally while denying ultimate validity to all *pramāṇas*.
- MEMORY: **Verdict**: Cārvāka loses the war and wins a battle — inference survives as **warranted**, not as **indubitable**.

Register 5 — Metaphysics and materialism

- FACT: **Bridging principle**: ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *pramāṇas*. Name it as a **presupposition**.
- FACT: *prthivyāptejovāyuriti tattvāni* — four *bhūtas*; *tatsamudāye śarīrendriya-viśaya-saṃjñā* — bodies, senses and objects from their combination.
- FACT: Living organisms too are elemental combinations, "reduced on death" to the elements.
- FACT: **The elements are eternal; only their combinations arise and perish** (Sharma). Hence Cārvāka is a **realist** materialism, not a flux doctrine.
- FACT: **Ākāśa rejected** "because it is not perceived but inferred" — the Vaiśeṣika inference from sound to an imperceptible substrate is refused.
- ANALYSIS: Cārvāka's most defensible line on sound: naturalise it into the perceptible air, rather than abandon the substance–quality scheme he uses for the four elements.
- FACT: *kiṇvātibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam* — consciousness arises as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents.
- FACT: **Betel** (leaf, lime, nut -> red): **compositional** emergence. **Fermentation** (*guḍa* -> intoxicant): **transformational** emergence. Two analogies, two distinct objections answered.
- FACT: Consciousness is an "**epiphenomenon** or by-product of matter"; "matter secretes mind as liver secretes bile".
- ANALYSIS: **Explanatory gap**: redness and intoxication are public, third-person qualities; consciousness is private and first-personal. Best Cārvāka reply: the soul-hypothesis **renames** the gap rather than closing it.
- FACT: **Pot and potter**: clay is the material cause and the potter the efficient cause; the Cārvāka answers with *svabhāva* — "there is no proof that the objects of the world are the products of any design".
- FACT: **Three labels from the textbook**: naturalism (*svabhāvavāda*) · mechanism (*yadr̥cchāvāda*) · **positivism** ("believes only in positive facts or observable phenomena").

- ANALYSIS: **Two uses of svabhāva**: deflationary (regularity, with "neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future") and substantive (nature in place of God). The "empty label" objection bites only on the second.
- FACT: **Sadānanda's Vedāntasāra**: four materialist schools identify the self with the gross body, the senses, the vital breaths, or *manas*. Śāntarakṣita reports *Kambalāśvatara* holding that consciousness arises from the body **associated with vital breaths**.
- ANALYSIS: Cārvāka reaches materialism by an **anti-inferential** route; modern materialism by a thoroughly **inferential** one.

Register 6 — Self, body and consciousness

- FACT: *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ / caitanya-viśiṣṭa deha eva ātmā* — the person is the **living** body qualified by consciousness. Not the corpse; not "no self at all"; not identity with any single element.
- FACT: **Negative argument**: "the non-material soul is **never perceived**".
- FACT: **Positive argument**: "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind" — if the "I" were different from the body these would be **meaningless**.
- FACT: **Covariation**: injury, intoxication, ageing, sleep and disease visibly alter awareness.
- FACT: **Consequence**: "death of the body means the end of the individual"; questions of previous life, after-life, rebirth, heaven and hell "become meaningless".
- FACT: **Sharma's objection battery**: self-consciousness versus animal life · swoon, fits, epilepsy and dreamless sleep = body without consciousness · dreams = consciousness "without the living body", and the waking dreamer disowns the dream-body but **owns** the dream-consciousness · subject cannot be reduced to object · **co-existence is not causation** (light and sight; the two horns of a bull) · consciousness is "neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard" · consciousness is **private** · the self-manifestation regress · the non-existence of a surviving soul is equally undemonstrable.
- ANALYSIS: **Best evaluative line**: the evidence establishes **dependence**; dependence is compatible with the body being the **instrument** rather than the cause.
- FACT: **Memory**: Nyāya/Vedānta invoke *ātman* · Cārvāka invokes bodily-psychological continuity of one organism · Buddhism invokes *santāna*, *pratisandhāna* and (Yogācāra) *ālaya-vijñāna* carrying *bījas*.
- FACT: **2024 core contrast**: Cārvāka **relocates** the self into matter; Buddhism **dissolves** the self into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished.
- FACT: **Grounds**: Cārvāka's is epistemic (never perceived); Buddhism's is ontological (*pratītyasamutpāda*, *kṣaṇikavāda*) and soteriological (self-belief breeds *trṣṇā*).
- FACT: **Aftermaths**: Cārvāka ends the moral narrative at death; Buddhism preserves karma, rebirth and *nirvāṇa* without an owner.
- ANALYSIS: **The decisive refinement**: *rūpa* is itself one of the five *skandhas*, so Buddhist *anātman* rules out the Cārvāka body-self **by name**.
- ANALYSIS: **Foils**: **Puggalavāda** (Vātsīputrīya) inside Buddhism; **Sadānanda's four materialisms** inside Cārvāka.

Register 7 — Rejection of transcendent entities

- FACT: **The template**: X is imperceptible -> only inference or testimony could reach X -> neither is a *pramāṇa* -> X is unwarranted -> X is rejected.
- ANALYSIS: Note the gap between **withholding assent** and **denying**; the doxographies attribute denial ("the Cārvākas, therefore, prefer atheism"), the argument licenses only the weaker conclusion.
- FACT: **God falls twice**: epistemically (no *pramāṇa*) and explanatorily (*svabhāva* suffices; the world's objects are "fortuitous products of the elements").
- FACT: **Adṛṣṭa** is named among the casualties — "any unperceived law (like *adṛṣṭa*)". Its very name means "the unseen", making it the perfect test case.

- FACT: **Transmigration requires** a separable self, its survival, a carrier of desert, and knowledge of all three. Cārvāka cuts every one.
- FACT: **Heaven and hell** are "the inventions of the priests"; *svarga* rests on "the unproved existence of a life after death".
- FACT: **The liberation dilemma**: freedom of a soul (absurd — there is no soul) · freedom from all pain in this life (impossible — embodiment mixes pleasure and pain) · residue: *maraṇam eva apavargaḥ*, which "no wise man would willingly work for".
- ANALYSIS: *Maraṇam eva apavargaḥ* is a **reductio of the concept of mokṣa**, not a recommendation of death.
- FACT: **Three ritual reductions**: *śrāddha* and the traveller's food · food downstairs feeding a person upstairs · *jyotiṣṭoma* — "why do they not rather sacrifice their own old parents?" The last is an argument from **revealed preference**.
- FACT: *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*: the Agnihotra, the three Vedas, the three staves and ashes were "made by Nature as the livelihood of those destitute of knowledge and manliness"; "the three authors of the Vedas were buffoons, knaves and demons". □ Quote with a source-caution.
- ANALYSIS: **Cārvāka's uniqueness**: Sāṃkhya, Mīmāṃsā, Jainism and Buddhism are also non-theistic. Cārvāka alone derives its atheism from its **epistemology**, and alone discards *karma*, rebirth and liberation as well.
- ANALYSIS: Internal tension worth flagging: *svabhāvavāda* grounds regularity in fixed natures; *yadṛcchāvāda* calls the world "fortuitous".

Register 8 — Ethics and social meaning

- FACT: *kāma evaikaḥ puruṣārthaḥ* — enjoyment is the only end; **artha is its means**; *dharma* and *mokṣa* are rejected.
- FACT: *Dharma* falls on **epistemic** grounds: "virtue and vice are distinctions made by the scriptures, whose authority cannot be rationally accepted".
- FACT: **Criterion**: a good action yields a balance of pleasure; a bad one brings more pain than pleasure. Hence hedonism.
- FACT: **Dhūrta** (cunning / crude) versus **suśikṣita** (cultured / refined) Cārvākas — "the Cārvākas were not all of the same gross, uncultured type".
- FACT: **Evidence for refinement**: sixty-four fine arts (*catuḥ-śaṣṭi-kalāḥ*) · *daṇḍanīti* and *vārttā* incorporated into Lokāyata · some Cārvākas "regard the **king as God**", implying faith in society and its head.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana** is "the best positive evidence of refined hedonism", but he "believes in God and in life after death" and is a materialist only "according to a wider sense of the term" — one who explains higher phenomena by lower.
- FACT: **Vātsyāyana's regulation**: *brahmacarya*, urbanity (*nāgarika-vṛtti*), education of the senses through the arts; and the prudential argument that refusing to defer "would prevent a man even from the toil of cultivation and sowing seeds".
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta: "Egoistic hedonism in its gross form is **not compatible with social discipline**."
- ANALYSIS: **Sharma's counterweight**: "crude individual hedonism"; the school's downfall lay in "the denial of all human values"; **"the pleasure of the pig is certainly not the same as the pleasure of the philosopher."**
- □ **The "debt and ghee" verse** — "let him feed on ghee even though he runs in debt" — is preserved in the *Sarva-darśana-saṃgraha*, an opponent's compendium. Use with an explicit source-caution; its buried argument concerns the rationality of deferral under a finite horizon, and Vātsyāyana himself answers it.
- ANALYSIS: **Verdict**: Cārvāka's ethics is a coherent theory of **prudence** and an incomplete theory of **morality** — it supplies no qualitative ordering of pleasures and no independent account of other-regarding obligation.

Register 9 — Comparative synthesis and answer craft

Item	Register entry
2020 Jainism axes	FACT: 1 <i>pramāṇa</i> vs fivefold knowledge · 4 <i>bhūtas</i> vs 6 <i>dravyas</i> · <i>ākāśa</i> rejected vs accepted · no soul vs infinite <i>jīvas</i> with consciousness as inseparable essence · no <i>guṇa-paryāya</i> vs <i>utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya</i> · single standpoint vs <i>anekānta</i> , <i>naya</i> , <i>syādvāda</i> · no karma vs material karma (<i>bhāvabandha</i> , <i>dravyabandha</i>) · no liberation vs <i>mokṣa</i> and <i>kevala-jñāna</i>
Shared ground with Jainism	FACT: Both <i>nāstika</i> ; both realists about the perceptible world; both reject a creator God
2024 positivism verdict	ANALYSIS: Positivistic in spirit (empiricist criterion, anti-metaphysics, "meaningless" register — and the textbook itself applies the word), not in method (positivism runs on inference and has a constructive programme). Safer labels: radical empiricism , naturalistic materialism
The paradox to quote	ANALYSIS: Cārvāka reaches materialism by an anti-inferential route; modern materialism by an inferential one
Western convergences	ANALYSIS: Epicurus and Lucretius (materialism, this-worldliness) · Hume (induction unjustifiable) · Ayer (unverifiable metaphysics) · Comte (observable phenomena). Chatterjee and Datta themselves compare the Cārvāka view of inference to "the pragmatists and logical positivists" and the school's reputation to that of "the Epicureans of Greece"
10-mark spine	Thesis -> three doors -> one sharp addition (<i>upādhi</i> or self-refutation) -> verdict linking epistemology to the denial asked about
15-mark spine	Frame with the source caution -> full anti-inference argument -> the rival's positive case -> Cārvāka's best reply and its cost -> graded verdict with a named criterion
20-mark spine	Classify (epistemology generating metaphysics) -> theory of knowledge in full -> ontological consequences -> the demanded comparison on named axes -> two objections with replies and residual pressure -> criterion-named verdict
PYQ centre of gravity	FACT: 5 of 9 owned parts concern inference ; 2 the self and transcendent entities; 1 the Jaina comparison; 1 the positivism label
Criteria to name in verdicts	ANALYSIS: Evidential economy · explanatory adequacy · internal consistency · perceptual redeemability · moral sufficiency · historiographical reliability
The five safe verdicts	ANALYSIS: Critique of certainty, not a theory of knowledge · ontology impeccably derived, so vulnerability lies in the epistemology · wins on entailment, loses on <i>pramāṇa</i> -status · relocation versus dissolution of the self · complete prudence, incomplete morality
Final memory spine	MEMORY: ONE, FOUR, TWO, ZERO · three doors · wet fuel · betel and fermentation · "I am fat, I am lame, I am blind" · <i>maraṇam eva apavargaḥ</i> · <i>dhūrta</i> and <i>suśikṣita</i> · touchstone

End of the complete learning session.